



Innovative Guided Rehabilitation Employer Engagement Training (iGREET)

US Department of Education: Rehabilitation Services Administration
Rehabilitation Training Experimental and Innovative Training

Award Number: H263C190012

10/1/2019—12/31/2025

Project Officer: Felipe Lulli

Principal Investigators and Co-Directors: Cecilia Gandolfo and Julisa Cully

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The Program on Innovative Rehabilitation Training on Employer Engagement is a project of ExploreVR at the Institute for Community Inclusion, UMass Boston. ExploreVR offers VR agencies easy and convenient access to a range of VR research, related data, training and tools for planning, evaluation, and decision-making.



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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Program on Innovative Rehabilitation Training on Employer Engagement (PIRTEE)

The Program on Innovative Rehabilitation Training on Employer Engagement (PIRTEE) was designed to strengthen the capacity of vocational rehabilitation (VR) professionals and their partners to engage employers effectively. The overarching goal was to develop, implement, and sustain a comprehensive training program that equips VR professionals with evidence-based strategies aligned with the Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA). PIRTEE aimed to address systemic needs by creating four employer engagement modules; companion guides for leadership, supervisors, faculty, and trainers; and delivery formats that include virtual and online training options to advance the competencies of VR professionals to serve businesses better and create stronger business relationships, which would ultimately lead to improved opportunities for people with disabilities served through the VR system. PIRTEE met and exceeded the project goals through activities conducted from October 2019 through December 2025.

The PIRTEE Project Goals

1. Create and host a Curriculum Advisory Team (CAT) with diverse perspectives on employer engagement and training to help guide the development of curricula as part of an overall continuous improvement process.
2. Create well-designed training curricula incorporating new knowledge and existing learning objectives.
3. Deliver training to improve knowledge, skills, and competencies of new and existing professionals and paraprofessionals in the rehabilitation field and rehabilitation counseling programs.
4. Provide training to supervisors, leadership, and training directors to improve VR's capacity to engage employers through adoption of evidence-based practices and strategies.
5. Conduct a project evaluation and incorporate results of the evaluation into continuous improvement of the training program.
6. Conduct additional effective collaboration and dissemination activities.

Significant Achievements

The PIRTEE successfully launched virtual and online training cohorts and developed companion guides for VR agency leadership, supervisors, and trainers as well as for Rehabilitation Program faculty. The project also used capstone projects and communities of practice (CoPs) to reinforce learning and application. Dissemination efforts through ExploreVR and the National Clearinghouse of Rehabilitation Training Materials (NCRTM), along with collaborations with national networks, have amplified the project's reach and impact. Sustainability planning focused on embedding resources into widely accessed platforms and building internal capacity within agencies through the Train-the-Trainer model.

PIRTEE conducted the activities and deliverables listed in Table 1 over the course of the project's six years.



Table 1: PIRTEE Activity and Deliverables

Project Goals	Status
Goal 1: Form and engage Curriculum Advisory Team (CAT) to inform project activities	Established and engaged CAT
Goal 2: Create training modules on employer engagement a. Create and pilot curriculum b. Create accessible online modules in learning management system c. Develop 3 companion guides per module (leadership/supervisor, trainer, faculty)	a. Developed 4 employer engagement virtual modules b. Developed 4 employer engagement online modules c. Created leadership/supervisor, faculty, and trainer companion guides
Goal 3: Provide training on employer engagement a. Conduct virtual and online iGREET b. Implement employer engagement Communities of Practice (CoP) c. Conduct virtual and in-person workshops through Training-on-Demand and conference presentations	a. Conduct iGREET: • 961 individuals enrolled in Module 1, 957 in Module 2, 958 in Module 3, and 957 in Module 4. • 577 individuals completed Module 1, 504 in Module 2, 469 in Module 3, and 434 in Module 4, surpassing the target of 125 participants by 347–461% across the 4 modules c. Conduct workshops: • 451 individuals attended workshops meeting our target of 280–480 participants
Goal 4: Deliver training using the companion guides a. Leadership training b. Supervisors training c. Train-the-trainer (T-CoP)	a. Leadership training: 138 individuals enrolled and 105 completed the training, surpassing the target of 80 participants by 131% b. Supervisor training: 205 individuals enrolled and 152 completed the training, surpassing the target of 80 participants by 190% c. T-CoP: 52 individuals enrolled and 37 completed the training, surpassing the target of 25 participants by 148%
Goal 5: Evaluation	Implemented a comprehensive evaluation and continuous quality improvement plan
Goal 6: Collaboration and dissemination	Implemented a comprehensive dissemination plan in collaboration with key stakeholders

Challenges

While PIRTEE achieved its objectives, the project encountered several challenges that required adaptive strategies. Early delays in hiring key staff and the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic significantly impacted timelines for curriculum development and piloting. Travel restrictions necessitated a shift from planned in-person sessions to virtual delivery, which required additional time and resources to design interactive online experiences. Recruitment posed challenges in later years, particularly for CoP participation, as competing work priorities and staff turnover affected engagement. Technical issues in the online learning management system (LMS) and evaluation processes, such as navigation difficulties and pre-post test administration, required iterative refinements.

Additional challenges included trainee retention, with many participants unable to complete training or capstone projects due to staffing shortages and increased workloads. Faculty engagement proved difficult despite targeted outreach and positive feedback on the faculty guide. Sustainability planning required balancing resource constraints with the need for ongoing updates to maintain relevance in a rapidly changing labor market.



Lessons Learned and Recommendations

Over the course of six years, PIRTEE demonstrated that building employer engagement capacity within VR systems requires flexibility, collaboration, and continuous improvement. Several key lessons emerged:

- » **Flexibility is essential.** The shift from in-person to virtual and online formats during the COVID-19 pandemic highlighted the importance of adaptable delivery models. Future training initiatives should incorporate multiple modalities from the outset to ensure accessibility and resilience.
- » **Interactive learning drives engagement.** Participants consistently valued real-world case scenarios, peer discussions, and opportunities to apply concepts. Embedding scenario-based exercises and CoPs into training design enhances knowledge retention and practical application.
- » **Leadership buy-in matters.** Agency leaders play a critical role in sustaining employer engagement practices. Training targeted to leadership and supervisors should remain a priority to ensure organizational alignment and resource allocation.
- » **Retention requires ongoing support.** Attrition in later cohorts and CoPs underscores the need for structured follow-up, flexible scheduling, and incentives such as continuing education credits to maintain engagement.
- » **Faculty integration is challenging but critical.** Despite positive feedback on the Faculty Companion Guide, uptake was limited. Future efforts should include stronger partnerships with academic programs and professional associations to embed employer engagement content into pre-service curricula.

Recommendations for the Field

- » Develop hybrid training models that combine virtual, online, and in-person options.
- » Incorporate capstone projects and peer learning opportunities to reinforce application.
- » Engage leadership early and provide tools for agency-wide implementation.
- » Explore partnerships with higher education and credentialing bodies to expand reach.
- » Continue refining content to reflect emerging practices, including technology-driven strategies such as artificial intelligence (AI) in employer engagement.

Sustainability

Sustainability was embedded in PIRTEE's design and strengthened through strategic planning in Years 5 and 6. Key elements include:

- » **Public Access to Training Materials:** All iGREET modules, companion guides, and resources have been uploaded to ExploreVR and NCRTM, ensuring continued availability beyond the grant period. The asynchronous online course remains in the Canvas Catalog for ongoing use.
- » **Integration into Existing Toolkits:** Employer Engagement Core Competencies and related tools have been incorporated into the ExploreVR Business Engagement Toolkit, supporting alignment with national VR resources.
- » **Train-the-Trainer Model:** The T-CoP equipped VR agencies with internal capacity to deliver iGREET independently. Many participants have continued to use the Trainer Guide and online modules for onboarding and professional development.
- » **Emerging Champions:** Several VR agencies and Tribal VR programs have adopted iGREET as part of their workforce initiatives, demonstrating the curriculum's adaptability and long-term value.
- » **Future Expansion:** With the award of iGREET 2.0, sustainability efforts will extend to new audiences, including Tribal VR programs and additional workforce partners, while updating content to reflect evolving labor market trends and technological innovations.

These strategies ensure that the impact of PIRTEE will continue well beyond the life of the grant, positioning VR agencies to maintain and advance employer engagement practices nationwide.



PROGRAM NARRATIVE

The Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act of 2014 (WIOA) articulated the importance of business as a critical customer for all workforce programs. To meet these requirements successfully, the vocational rehabilitation (VR) system needs to increase staff capacity to engage employers through the acquisition of relevant competencies. This requires training on relevant emerging practices, strategies, and use of existing tools. For there to be a systematic change in the way VR works with the business community, these trainings need to be available to VR counselors, business engagement specialists, VR leadership, and other rehabilitation professionals.

The Program on Innovative Rehabilitation Training on Employer Engagement (PIRTEE) developed training to advance the competencies of existing staff to serve businesses better and create stronger business relationships, which will ultimately lead to improved opportunities for people with disabilities served through the VR system. PIRTEE integrated research, emerging evidence, and tools from the [ExploreVR Business Engagement toolkit](#) into the training to develop modules for the VR system, rehabilitation professionals and paraprofessionals, and faculty in rehabilitation counseling programs.

Continuous quality improvement and sustainability were the cornerstones of the PIRTEE. To that effect, the project convened a Curriculum Advisory Team (CAT) representing state VR agencies, national training experts, rehabilitation counseling programs, and Native American Studies academic programs to provide guidance on content development and training implementation at all stages of the project. Online (asynchronous) training modules were developed for continued use after the project ended.

This report includes information on the activities carried out throughout the six years of the project, from October 2019 through December 2025. PIRTEE activities and deliverables are categorized under the six primary project goals:

1. Curriculum Advisory Team (CAT)
2. Development of training curricula
3. Training to professionals and paraprofessionals in the rehabilitation field
4. Training to supervisors, leadership, and training directors
5. Evaluation
6. Collaboration and dissemination activities.

Supplemental material is available in the Appendices section.

GOAL 1: CURRICULUM ADVISORY TEAM

Establish and maintain a Curriculum Advisory Team (CAT) with diverse perspectives on employer engagement and training to help guide the development of curricula as part of an overall continuous improvement process.

Overview and Alignment to Purpose

The Curriculum Advisory Team (CAT) played a central role in informing, shaping, and validating the development of PIRTEE's employer engagement curriculum and related training products. The CAT was established in Year 1 and expanded in Year 2. CAT members represented a broad range of expertise (see *Appendix A* for list of CAT members):

- » VR (directors of Blind, General, and Tribal Agencies, training director, and business account manager)



- » Higher Education [associate dean of School for Global Inclusion and Social Development (SGISD) and its Rehabilitation Counseling Program, the director of the New England Native American Studies Program, and Workforce Innovation Technical Assistance Center (WINTAC) director/ San Diego State University Interwork Institute]
- » CSAVR & National Business Contacts (director of business relations and the National Employment Team lead)
- » Knowledge Translation for Employment Research [director of the Knowledge Translation for Employment Research (KTER) Center who is also doing research on employer engagement strategies]
- » Expertise in training for the VR system (WINTAC director and business engagement team)
- » Curriculum development (all faculty, training experts, and VR training director)
- » Unique and consumer perspectives: Blind VR and Native American Studies

Their guidance ensured that project deliverables aligned with VR system needs, emerging practices, and the expectations of WIOA-related partners.

Major Activities and Accomplishments

Establishment of the CAT

The project successfully identified, recruited, and convened a diverse advisory group whose expertise aligned with project goals. The infrastructure was established using Microsoft Teams, Zoom, and Qualtrics to support ongoing communication, document sharing, and collaborative feedback. The CAT was formally launched in January 2020 and immediately began providing input on curriculum priorities.

Guidance on Curriculum Development

Throughout curriculum development, the CAT was actively engaged through surveys, virtual meetings, structured brainstorming activities, and iterative review processes. The CAT was convened quarterly and tasked with reviewing and validating topic areas for all four curriculum modules. The project team initially planned to develop and launch all four modules simultaneously. CAT recommended a staggered development and release strategy (Modules 1–2 first, followed by Modules 3–4). The first two modules provided foundational information, which had a lot of relevance to existing field practices and key areas of need. They helped identify the core sub-topics to be included:

1. **Module 1:** VR structure, partnerships, processes, and emerging strategies
2. **Module 2:** Elevator pitches, working collaboratively with community partners, and data collection

A major milestone was the two-day virtual CAT meeting in August 2020, which resulted in substantial refinement of all core curriculum components and validated the training framework for delivery. It was initially planned as an in-person meeting but was adapted to a virtual format due to COVID-19.

At the quarterly meetings, the CAT assisted with identifying research and field-initiated emerging practices in employer engagement and providing real-world examples for training scenarios (e.g., internships & apprenticeships, on-the-job training and other work-based learning strategies). Another topical area identified as crucial to employer engagement was the dual-customer approach to relationship building for enhanced opportunities. In addition to input on the content topical areas, the CAT provided feedback on learning objectives, module structure, content emphasis, and alignment with VR practice. They provided guidance on the companion guides for supervisors, leadership, and faculty.



Upon completion of the virtual training pilot, CAT members reviewed pilot assessment findings and recommended the use of scenario-based questions to better measure applied knowledge. They made recommendations for strengthening the curriculum in response to the following key participant feedback themes:

- » Value of peer interaction and real-case scenarios
- » Need for more business-focused language
- » Importance of ethics and cultural considerations
- » Learning from other states' practices
- » Redundancies needing streamlining

In addition to post-pilot revisions being made to the curriculum, there were three additional points in time when significant revisions were made: in Year 3 when the online modules were developed, in Year 5 when the virtual training was delivered to a cohort composed of all community rehabilitation provider (CRP) staff, and in Year 6 in order to meet Executive Order compliance.

The content for the virtual and the online trainings is the same, but the presentation of the information differs significantly based on Universal Design for Learning (UDL) principles. Therefore, the online training was also piloted (see Goal #2 for additional detail). Two CAT members volunteered to pilot the online iGREET modules along with VR professionals in the field. They offered critical insight on the design, accessibility, navigation, and user experience.

Guidance of Companion Guides and Capstones

In addition to the curriculum development, the CAT was consulted on the development of the companion guides and the capstone projects. They provided recommendations on key features, how to structure and package the information, and dissemination and recruitment strategies for the related trainings.

The Leadership/Supervisor guide was developed to provide agency leadership and supervisors practical tips and resources for encouraging and supporting the application of knowledge and skills acquired through the iGREET. The CAT recommended the introduction include prompts for administrators and supervisors to think about their current employer practices and what they want to work on. Using the guide from this starting point can help them identify strategies to progress forward. They also recommended incorporating examples of what is being done by different state agencies to highlight business services successes and challenges. There should be sections on WIOA partnerships, data collection, and on how are partnerships formed across the core partners to meet business needs.

CAT provided guidance on how to structure the Faculty and Training Director Guides, for best alignment with VR training and higher education program curricula so that the content provides resources and augments existing curricula. Based on the discussions, the faculty guide provides a crosswalk between the iGREET curriculum and Council for Accreditation of Counseling and Related Educational Programs (CACREP) standards. The





recommendations for the Training Director Guide primarily focused on the capstone project best practices for using capstones in training. Several members of the CAT had experience conducting CoPs and trainings with a capstone element. They shared that participants are likely to ask, “what is in it for me?”. They suggested forums for the participants to showcase their work with the broader VR community. CAT members suggested acceptance to the CoP and capstone project be a competitive process elevating it to a privileged status, and they encouraged the project team to connect with the Program Evaluation and Quality Assurance (PEQA) Technical Assistance Center regarding their process. The last recommendation was to explore offering continuing education credits, in addition to Certified Rehabilitation Counselor (CRC) credits, for other professional associations. The CAT also provided recommendations on dissemination and outreach to the two target audiences.

Expansion and Targeted Expertise

As training development progressed, additional experts were added to the CAT in Year 2 Quarter 4, to strengthen representation in key areas such as Tribal VR, workforce development, and employer services. These members contributed to ensuring the curriculum remained both relevant and responsive to the diversity of VR systems and local practices.

With curriculum development completed by the end of Year 3, the role of the CAT transitioned from full-group convenings to individualized, “as-needed” consultation. This shift was made to respect members’ time and avoid unnecessary meetings and focus on implementation, outreach, and dissemination. This allowed PIRTEE to leverage members’ specialized expertise for specific technical questions related to training, employer engagement practices, academic faculty engagement, and agency leadership issues. CAT supported recruitment for the online training, the Trainer Community of Practice (T-CoP) and outreach to academic faculty and VR partners. All CAT members were consulted for guidance on sustainability and long-term dissemination.

Outcomes and Impact

The CAT was successfully established, actively engaged during all phases of curriculum development, and strategically repositioned to support implementation and dissemination. All planned activities were completed on schedule, and CAT contributions substantially strengthened deliverables across the project including the following:

1. **High-quality, relevant curriculum products:** CAT collaboration ensured that the four iGREET modules and companion guides were grounded in field services; were culturally responsive; and aligned with VR employer engagement values, ethics, and promising practices.
2. **Enhanced field relevance and usability:** Through CAT input, the curriculum includes:
 - » real-world examples and scenarios
 - » updated employer engagement language
 - » cross-state strategies and emerging practices
 - » ethical and cultural considerations

These improvements increased training applicability for VR staff across roles.

3. **Strengthened national collaboration:** The CAT fostered connections among VR agencies, national partners, and university programs, supporting broader adoption and dissemination efforts.
4. **Sustainable advisory model:** By transitioning CAT engagement to targeted consultation, the project established a model that supports both ongoing implementation and future scalability and reduced the time commitment burden for CAT members.



GOAL 2: DEVELOPMENT OF TRAINING CURRICULA

Develop, pilot, finalize, and implement a Comprehensive Employer Engagement Curriculum (iGREET).

Table 2: Corresponding Status Chart Performance Data

Status Chart #3 Measures b & d			
Performance Measure	Measure Type	Target	Actual Performance
Number of Training Modules converted to Online Modules	Project	4	4/4
LMS to house Online Modules	Project	1	1/1

*Note, the leadership and supervisor guides are combined in one document. There is a general overview applicable to both audiences and then a section specific to each group.

Overview and Alignment to Purpose

The PIRTEE developed and delivered comprehensive training modules on employer engagement to strengthen VR practices nationwide. This goal aligns with the project's overarching purpose of equipping VR professionals with evidence-based strategies to meet WIOA mandates and enhance partnerships with businesses. The training series, titled Innovative Guided Rehabilitation Employer Engagement Training (iGREET), was designed to address emerging and promising practices, foster relationship-building with employers, improve collaboration with WIOA partners, and provide practical tools for implementation. The curriculum development process was informed by extensive research, stakeholder input from the CAT, and iterative feedback from pilot participants, ensuring relevance and applicability to the VR field. The curriculum consists of four modules designed for synchronous and asynchronous training. In response to COVID-19 disruptions, all planned in-person content in Years 1–3 was transitioned into a high-quality, virtual format.

Modules 1 and 2 were piloted in late 2020 and Modules 3 and 4 in spring 2021; each pilot incorporated participant feedback, which led to streamlined content, improved pacing, enriched cultural and ethical considerations, and strengthened application through case studies and scenario-based learning.

In Years 3–4, the curriculum was redesigned into a fully asynchronous online training housed in the Canvas LMS, featuring multimedia videos, branching scenarios, embedded knowledge checks, and accessibility enhancements. The online





curriculum was also piloted to ensure usability and flow. Additional refinements were made based on user data and field needs, including CRP applicability and navigation improvements. Goal 2 was fully achieved, resulting in a high-quality, nationally relevant, and sustainable training system designed to strengthen VR professionals' competencies and enhance employer engagement outcomes.

This curriculum includes four instructional modules delivered in both virtual instructor-led and fully asynchronous online formats, supported by a suite of companion guides for VR supervisors, leaders, faculty, and trainers (see Goal 4). Training-on-Demand was also available starting in Year 4. Agencies could select from a menu of topics from the four modules, which were tailored to their agency needs.

The curriculum was designed through iterative development that incorporated findings from a national environmental scan, CAT expertise, pilot outcomes, and participant feedback. This goal directly supports the project's purpose to strengthen VR professionals' competencies in employer engagement and to improve employment outcomes for people with disabilities.

"The training provided current content and guidance needed to engage with employers in a meaningful way, building trust and relationships beneficial to all parties involved. In my state, we are adding employment specialists to VR staff and part of that role is employer engagement and building these relationships." —Training Participant

Major Activities and Accomplishments

Curriculum Development and Resource Review

Over six years, the PIRTEE team successfully developed four core training modules, each comprising multiple lessons, and adapted them for both virtual and online delivery formats. The project began by creating a development and review structure in partnership with the CAT and conducting an extensive review of national employer engagement and VR training materials to identify evidence-based and emerging practices. This included translating, adapting, and improving existing Job-Driven VR Technical Assistance Center (JDVRTAC) and other leading technical assistance centers and clearing houses (e.g., WINTAC, NRTC, KTER, and NCTRM) toolkits and resources. Modules 1–2 provide foundational competencies. Modules 3–4 were developed upon completion of the first two modules and focused on moving beyond the basics. Modules 3–4 include employer engagement during unique circumstances; rural and Tribal VR contexts; and dual-customer employment models, such as apprenticeship, customized employment, and progressive engagement models (see Appendix B for module descriptions).

Module 1: Foundations of Employer Engagement

Module 2: Developing and Maximizing Partnerships for Employer Engagement

Module 3: Individualized Employer Engagement

Module 4: Employment Models to Meet Business Needs

All modules were delivered virtually via Zoom, incorporating interactive features such as breakout rooms, polls, and case scenarios. Concurrently, the team developed asynchronous online modules hosted on Canvas, featuring multimedia elements, interactive activities, and knowledge checks to enhance learner engagement.



Piloting (Virtual Delivery)

Despite initial delays due to staffing and COVID-19, the team implemented a staggered rollout strategy, piloting, beta testing, and refining course material based on participant data, pre-post assessments, and other sources as relevant to the learning object. Modules 1 and 2 were piloted in late 2020 using a virtual, instructor-led format via Zoom. Each lesson incorporated multimedia presentation, case-based discussion, breakout groups, ethics-focused content, knowledge assessments, and immediate feedback mechanisms. Participants provided rich feedback that guided content refinement, pacing adjustments, and improved application-based learning. Modules 3 and 4 were piloted in Spring 2021. Feedback confirmed the value of the content and highlighted the needs for more time for scenario-based discussions, streamlined presentation materials, and enhanced cultural considerations. Comprehensive revisions were made to all four modules following pilot findings.

Online Learning Management System (LMS)

The team translated all curriculum content into an asynchronous format to be delivered in Canvas LMS. The content across the four modules remained consistent with the virtual lessons, but the order and presentation of the material was revised for flow and user engagement using Universal Design for Learning (UDL) principles and resulted with 15 online lessons. The online modules included actor-based and field services example videos, branching scenarios, interactive case studies, knowledge checks embedded throughout lessons, and a narrator to guide learners through course.

Although piloting of online modules was not required, the project conducted full pilots to ensure accessibility, flow, and learner engagement. Pilot feedback prompted improvements to navigation, clarity, and sequencing.

Companion Guide Development

To support sustainability and broader adoption, companion guides were created for key audiences: leadership, supervisors, faculty, and trainers.

- » **Leadership & Supervisor Companion Guide:** Combined for ease of use and aligned with VR organizational needs
- » **Trainer Companion Guide:** Introduced to guide facilitation strategies and support fidelity in agency-led training
- » **Faculty Companion Guide:** Created for integration into postsecondary rehabilitation counseling programs, including CACREP and Commission on Accreditation of Allied Health Education Programs (CAAHEP) crosswalks

These guides provide tailored strategies for applying the curriculum within agencies and academic programs, including crosswalks to CACREP and CAAHEP standards for faculty. A Train-the-Trainer guide and Community of Practice (T-CoP) were launched to build internal training capacity within VR agencies. Each guide includes module-by-module breakdowns, learning objectives, discussion prompts, implementation considerations, and contextualized examples. Feedback from pilots and cohorts informed refinements to content structure and navigation features. By Year 4, all modules and guides were finalized, and the online course was launched nationally. Subsequent years focused on recruitment, delivery to diverse cohorts—including CRPs—and continuous improvement based on field input and emerging trends, such as integrating AI into employer engagement practices.



Final Curriculum Completion and Public Launch

The online curriculum was fully launched in October 2022, with refinements continuing in subsequent months based on user data and trainer feedback. Key updates included reorganization of modules to enhance accessibility and coherence, including the reintegration of CRP-focused content directly into required modules; removal of discussion boards to improve flow; and adding a requirement that learners score at least 80% to pass module post-tests and receive certificate of completion and CRC credits. All curriculum elements, virtual delivery materials, online modules, assessments, and companion guides were finalized and integrated into a long-term training infrastructure.



Outcomes and Impact

The development and dissemination of the iGREET series have significantly advanced the capacity of VR professionals to engage employers effectively. The curriculum is designed for both remote and in-person environments and is supported by professionally designed LMS infrastructure.

Over multiple cohorts, hundreds of participants completed the training, reporting increased knowledge of WIOA requirements, improved confidence in applying employer engagement strategies, and greater awareness of cultural and ethical considerations. The inclusion of interactive elements and real-world scenarios fostered practical skill-building, while the online format expanded access and flexibility for agencies nationwide. Companion guides have enhanced the utility of the curriculum by providing actionable tools for leadership, supervisors, faculty, and trainers, supporting systemic integration of employer engagement practices.

The project's impact extends beyond individual learning outcomes to organizational change. Agencies have reported adopting new strategies for business engagement, leveraging partnerships more effectively, and aligning practices with federal mandates. The T-CoP has created a sustainable infrastructure for ongoing professional development, ensuring that the curriculum continues to influence VR practice beyond the life of the grant. By Year 6, PIRTEE has established a comprehensive, adaptable training framework that addresses current needs and anticipates future trends, positioning VR agencies to better serve both job seekers and business customers.



GOAL 3: TRAINING TO PROFESSIONALS AND PARAPROFESSIONALS IN THE REHABILITATION FIELD

Provide iGREET to improve knowledge, skills, and competencies of new and existing professionals and paraprofessionals in the rehabilitation field and rehabilitation counseling programs.

Table 3: Corresponding Status Chart Performance Data

Status Chart #1 Performance Data			
Module 1			
Performance Measure	Measure Type	Target	Actual Performance
Number of individuals enrolled in the training Module 1	Program	125	961
Number of individuals who successfully complete the Module 1	Program	125	577
The quality of the training developed for Module 1, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	93.6%
The relevance of the training developed for Module 1, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	98.4%
The usefulness of the training developed for Module 1, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	96.5%
Module 2			
Performance Measure	Measure Type	Target	Actual Performance
Number of individuals enrolled in the training Module 2	Program	125	957
Number of individuals who successfully complete the Module 2	Program	125	504
The quality of the training developed for Module 2, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	95.3%
The relevance of the training developed for Module 2, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	98.5%
The usefulness of the training developed for Module 2, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	96.1%
Module 3			
Performance Measure	Measure Type	Target	Actual Performance
Number of individuals enrolled in the training Module 3	Program	125	958
Number of individuals who successfully complete the Module 3	Program	125	469
The quality of the training developed for Module 3, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	95.4%
The relevance of the training developed for Module 3, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	97.4%
The usefulness of the training developed for Module 3, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	96.5%
Module 4			
Performance Measure	Measure Type	Target	Actual Performance
Number of individuals enrolled in the training Module 4	Program	125	957
Number of individuals who successfully complete the Module 4	Program	125	434
The quality of the training developed for Module 4, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	96.4%
The relevance of the training developed for Module 4, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	99.1%
The usefulness of the training developed for Module 4, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	97.6%
In-person / Virtual Conference Workshops and Training-on-Demand			
Performance Measure	Measure Type	Target	Actual Performance
Number of individuals that attended the training workshops	Program	240-480	451



Overview and Alignment to Purpose

The PIRTEE delivered employer engagement training to VR professionals and partners through virtual instructor-led training, asynchronous online delivery, and in-person/virtual workshops and Training-on-Demand. This goal aligns with the project's purpose of equipping staff with evidence-based strategies to meet WIOA mandates and strengthen partnerships with businesses. The curriculum includes four comprehensive modules, each addressing critical aspects of employer engagement, from foundational principles to advanced strategies and employment models. The training delivery activities included developing and implementing recruitment strategies, piloting the iGREET, evaluating the training program and GPRA measures, and preparing for large-scale national rollout. Over the course of the project, recruitment efforts evolved from targeted outreach to broader national recruitment, supporting both pilot delivery and ongoing training implementation.

“Communication is key, so continuing to share the vision to staff, and continuing the use of our database to share our communications with businesses, so other staff and partner agencies have access to that information.” —Training Participant

Major Activities and Accomplishments

Over the course of six years, PIRTEE successfully launched multiple cohorts of virtual and online training, reaching hundreds of participants from VR agencies and CRPs nationwide.

Virtual Synchronous Training

Beginning in Year 1, the project finalized and delivered all four modules through highly structured virtual training cohorts. Each module consisted of multiple 2-hour lessons facilitated by two trainers with support staff who managed technology, breakout rooms, polls, transcription, and accessibility. The virtual format was intentionally interactive, incorporating small and large group discussions, ethics corner segments, scenario-based exercises, labor market information analysis, and a range of application activities. The lessons emphasized relationship building and meeting the employer where they are, communication and business-friendly language, and practical strategies for applying concepts in real-world settings.

Recruitment began with a pilot phase in Year 2, where 227 individuals from over 30 states expressed interest, and 36 were selected for the initial pilot cohort based on geographic diversity, experience level, and job responsibilities related to employer engagement. Subsequent cohorts expanded participation significantly, with later years seeing increased enrollment from CRPs to foster collaboration between VR agencies and contracted partners. In Year 5, the virtual cohort consisted exclusively of CRP staff, necessitating slight curriculum adjustments to ensure applicability to CRP roles.

The project began by designing a recruitment strategy targeted at securing two pilot agencies—one General agency and one Blind agency—that could represent diverse organizational structures and employer engagement practices. However, the onset of COVID-19 made traditional in-person pilots not feasible. In response, the project quickly adapted by shifting to a fully virtual pilot model and expanding recruitment to a national audience, which ultimately increased representation, accessibility, and real-time feedback from a broader cross-section of VR professionals. During Years 1 and 2, recruitment efforts included direct outreach to VR administrators, dissemination through Council of State Administrators of Vocational Rehabilitation (CSAVR) networks, targeted communications to state business relations units, and a recruitment flyer circulated nationally. These efforts were highly successful, resulting in robust participation across the instructor-



led pilots of Modules 1 and 2 in late 2020 and Modules 3 and 4 in spring 2021. VR counselors, business engagement specialists, supervisors, program directors, and staff from both General and Blind agencies, participated in the pilot of the virtual training, which included synchronous videoconference training, pre-post assessments, trainer presentations, polls, small and large group discussions, case scenarios, surveys, and qualitative feedback mechanisms.

The participants' contributions significantly strengthened the curriculum. The training received positive feedback overall and maintained a high-level of engagement. Participants reported the training was highly relevant to VR; they appreciated the virtual accessibility and they expressed interest in continued participation. Pilot participants provided detailed input on pacing, clarity, cultural relevance, format, and real-world application, leading to major curriculum refinements across all four modules.

Most of the cohorts consisted primarily of state VR agency staff. In Year 5, the virtual training experienced an anomaly with a cohort comprised exclusively of CRPs. Anecdotally, the PIRTEE team was informed this was in part due to state VR agencies encouragement to complete the training for better alignment of employer engagement strategies across the two programs. Some individuals also reported learning about the training through conference presentations and newsletters. Having a cohort of CRPs required tweaking of some of the language used in the scripting. This led the PIRTEE team to also make similar changes to the online modules for broader applicability to VR providers outside of the state VR agencies as well as personnel from other WIOA partners. In Year 6, there was a targeted outreach effort to both VR agencies and CRPs in hopes of having representatives from both groups. This enriched the discussions, enhanced collaboration, and lent itself to the application and sustainability of solid employer engagement practices. Training participants were from 38 state VR agencies; one American Indian VR (AIVR) program (Native Program: Mississippi Choctaw VR); 18 community rehabilitation programs (CRPs) across 38 states; and one WIOA partner, such as America Job Centers, Developmental Disability Agencies, Veteran Health Administration, and Veteran Affairs. All the cohorts experienced attrition rates in participation due to new roles and/or task assignments and shift in workload, retirement/leaving the agency, medical leave, and non-engagement or response to outreach efforts.

There were several notable stories that highlight the impact of the virtual training. This first Impact Story highlights the Oregon Vocational Rehabilitation Services.

Impact Story: Oregon Vocational Rehabilitation Services

Staff from Oregon Vocational Rehabilitation Services (OVRs) iGREET virtual training course immediately demonstrated interest in the content, actively participated in discussions, and provided examples of how they planned to implement the content presented. During the next T-CoP session that was offered, the OVRs agency sent three staff members and has since used the iGREET Trainer Guide and online asynchronous course to train CRP as well as additional OVRs staff. This example demonstrates that the iGREET courses and materials support a wider range of professional staff beyond that of state VR agencies.

Asynchronous Online Course

To expand national access and support self-paced learning, the project converted the full curriculum into an online format delivered through an LMS (Canvas). By late Year 3, the team piloted the full online curriculum with VR staff from multiple states and two CAT members. The



online course received strong interest and positive early user feedback. Following an initial pilot and refinements to navigation, accessibility, and user experience, the online iGREET courses launched in October 2022 and were offered three times annually thereafter. The online version offered self-paced learning through Canvas. Modules mirrored the virtual content but included additional features, such as interactive case scenarios, videos, infographics, and knowledge checks. Initially, a bonus lesson on partnering with CRPs was added to address unique collaboration needs but analytics data showed that only two participants had clicked on the optional lesson. The decision was made that based on participant and leadership input, there was a need for the content covered in the lesson, and the information was incorporated into the partnership lesson. Participants accessed content in multiple formats, including scripted videos, branching scenarios, and mini presentations, ensuring engagement and accessibility.

As the project transitioned to building the fully online iGREET modules in Canvas LMS, recruitment expanded even further. In Years 3 and 4, the team launched a national Outreach and Recruitment Workgroup to support long-term, systematic dissemination efforts. This group developed a centralized communication process, identified high-potential partner states, monitored registration patterns, created promotional materials and coordinated ongoing recruitment cycles for both the online training cohorts and the T-CoP.

The expanded recruitment efforts were met with overwhelming interest. The Spring 2023 online cohort enrolled 111 participants, surpassing expectations. Additional waves of VR staff, CRPs, and higher education partners continued to register throughout the year. This strong demand affirmed the national relevance and usability of the iGREET. Training participants were from 38 state VR agencies; four AIVRs programs (Native Programs: Mississippi Choctaw VR, Samish Indian Nation, Seneca Nation VR, and Bristol Bay Native Association); 92 CRPs across 26 states; and six WIOA partners, such as America Job Center, Developmental Disability Agencies, Veteran Health Administration and Veteran Affairs.

Employer Engagement Communities of Practice (CoPs)

To reinforce learning and promote application, PIRTEE introduced an Employer Engagement CoP alongside training cohorts. CoP sessions provided a forum for participants to share experiences, discuss challenges, and explore strategies for employer engagement. The CoP hosted monthly meetings over an 8-month period starting in Year 2. The CoP sessions were semi-structured based on participant-selected topics and addressed real-world challenges, such as engaging counselors in business development, collaborating with CRPs, working with the Office of Federal Contract Compliance Programs (OFCCP), improving messaging to employers, and navigating multi-partner relationships. Sessions 2-5 focused on the module delivered that month. Participants were asked to share how they had applied the principles from the module and successes and challenges from those efforts. For sessions 6-7, the group identified 1-2 topics for discussion at the end of the previous session. Session 8 was dedicated to presenting the capstone projects.

Participants were encouraged to complete capstone projects, such as developing employer surveys or creating presentations on work-based learning models (see Impact Stories for capstone highlights). Early cohorts demonstrated strong engagement and peer-to-peer sharing of information, but participation in the CoPs declined in later years due to competing priorities. Cohort 1 had 41 individuals registered, with 41 individuals attending at least one session and 24 individuals attending three or more sessions. Two participants chose to complete the implementation capstone. Cohort 2 had a total of 20 individuals registered with 14 individuals attending at least one session and 9 individuals attending three or more sessions. Cohort 3 had a total of 21 individuals registered for the CoP, 3 withdrew and 13 individuals have attended at least one session thus far. Cohort 4 had 19 participants registered, and 16 participants attended at least one session and 8 participants attended



at least four of the eight sessions. Only one participant chose to complete the implementation capstone. Cohort 5 had 14 participants registered to participate with 7 individuals attending the first session. We saw a gradual decline in attendance, to the point where only 1-2 participants joined sessions 4-8, despite targeted outreach to the group. Several members dropped out for family or personal health reasons and others were no longer working with their agency. As a result, the project team changed the format from CoP to office hours, which were meant to address their employer engagement challenges. Those who participated stated that they found the office hours to be very relevant and useful.

For staff who participated in the iGREET (either online, virtual, or in-person), PIRTEE made a CoP on Employer Engagement available. This CoP would meet monthly for 8-10 months. The purpose was for the members to come together to share successes, challenges, and strategies as they applied their iGREET to their day-to-day employer engagement activities at their jobs. While members were strongly encouraged to consider undertaking a specific employer engagement project, our experience was that mostly people only had time to tweak their approaches to working with businesses, and frequently shared resources, strategies, and discussed ideas for application. The individuals who took on a capstone project, however, did so with an impressive amount of consideration, ingenuity, and diligence. The Impact Stories on page xxx include three examples of capstone projects shared with the group.

Conference Presentations and Training-on-Demand

In addition to the virtual and online trainings, the PIRTEE conducted workshops at conferences and Training-on-Demand by request. The PIRTEE conducted 13 workshops with a total of 451 individuals participating. Table 4 (on page 4) provides a list of the workshops.

Outcomes and Impact

The iGREET series has significantly enhanced the capacity of VR professionals and CRPs to engage employers effectively. The project established a scalable, flexible, and responsive recruitment infrastructure; successfully transitioned from pilot recruitment to large-scale national delivery; generated strong engagement across multiple VR roles and states; and laid the foundation for ongoing dissemination well beyond the grant period. Across virtual, online, and workshops, 1,028 participants completed (2,435 completions for the itemized four modules) the iGREET, reporting increased confidence in applying employer engagement strategies, improved understanding of ethical considerations, and greater ability to build partnerships. The inclusion of CRPs in later cohorts strengthened collaboration between agencies and contracted providers, promoting alignment in business engagement practices.

Evaluation data and participant feedback highlight the value of interactive elements, cultural awareness, and practical tools provided through the training. Participants noted that learning about emerging practices and hearing examples from other states were particularly beneficial. The online format expanded access, allowing participants to complete modules at their own pace while maintaining engagement through multimedia features and knowledge checks. From conversations with training participants, the PIRTEE team has identified the following iGREET impact:

- » **VR Agencies:** Increased access to high-quality employer engagement training, improved consistency across staff roles, and new opportunities to embed training into onboarding and professional development.
- » **VR Field:** Broader awareness of employer engagement best practices and development of a national network of trained practitioners.
- » **Long-Term Sustainability:** A scalable, replicable recruitment infrastructure and ongoing national interest that extends beyond the project period.



Impact Stories: Capstone Projects

California Department of Rehabilitation (DOR) Regional Business Specialist's Project: Building Partnerships with CRPs, workforce development, and business through joint collaborations and presentations to businesses on on-the-job trainings (OJT), work opportunity tax credits (WOTCs), reasonable accommodations, and job fairs.

This CoP member explained that interagency collaboration had resulted in joint job fairs in three parts of the state, including targeted specific populations (homeless, substance abuse, justice involvement), but not people with disabilities. As such, this business specialist proposed and facilitated the following (along with his workforce partners):

These joint job fairs should be inclusive to job seekers with disabilities. In addition, he would run a 1-week workshop to prepare people on ways to promote themselves at the job fair.

A joint business training would be made available to provide a clear overview of OJT and WOTC. In the final CoP meeting, he presented his peers with a brief example of his training materials and related resources shared with businesses on OJT and WOTC. Training provided helped businesses to understand OJT and WOTC and the benefits of partnering with VR and Workforce development.

A summary report about this training featured the following:

Presenters described how a business could recover up to \$4,999.99 of training expenses used on new hires who are receiving services from the Department of Rehabilitation over 3 months; simultaneously, the WOTCs could help a business receive thousands of dollars in tax credits. Trainers also explained that businesses could receive support from DOR, thus saving the businesses time and increasing their overall revenues, by reducing onboarding costs while increasing diversity and inclusion of their workforce, which is good for individuals, families, businesses, employee morale, and the community, too.

Hawaii Division of VR Employment Service Specialist's Project: Use newly developed employer engagement skills to conduct a needs assessment of local businesses on the island of Kaua'i to inform her strategy for relationship development.

This CoP member developed a 10-question survey tool. After extensive efforts to communicate via mail and phone to 38 businesses, a total of 15 surveys were completed (either over the phone or a small number submitted in writing).

The participant's self-evaluation of her project yielded the following learnings:

- » Persistence and newly developed skills led to possible future endeavors, including: 1) an on-the-job training (OJT) opportunity within a business, 2) another business interested in a supported employment opportunity, 3) a business interested in developing work-based learning opportunities for youth in school, and 4) a government agency wanted to move forward with planning a Schedule A and workforce recruitment conversation for future hires.
- » Be persistent, keep trying to connect with businesses even when it seems tough to contact them. At first, lack of interest in my mailed outreach did not yield a lot of responses, but a follow-up through phone calls achieved better success.
- » Timing is key. Her initial outreach occurred near the Christmas season, which was not an ideal time.
- » Businesses consistently relayed the following responses: 1) interest in working with community agencies such as the Division of VR, 2) almost always experiencing challenges with recruiting qualified candidates, and 3) ambition, focus, and/or reliability are mentioned as traits lacking in many candidates and/or current employees.

Wisconsin DVR Business Service Consultant's Project: Exploring the use of individual business plans (IBPs) in engaging our business customers.

This CoP member piloted the use of a protocol to work with businesses. She noted that previously, all of her fellow business engagement specialists had their own ways to interact and plan to move forward. As a result, she developed an approach to implement consistency, including the following action steps:

- » Create templates: (one for a letter explaining the plan for an initial meeting; one for a summary report; and one Excel sheet to track businesses met, their needs/interests, if an IBP was developed, and other involvement with DVR)
- » Compose email to business to explain plan for initial information-gathering meeting
- » Implement meeting
- » Develop a summary report
- » Share summary with the business, confirm accuracy, and next steps.
- » Lessons learned: Businesses liked the clear communication and planning. IBP process helped the business relationships.

Barriers: National Disability Employment Awareness Month (NDEAM) is a busy time, followed by holidays. Best to restart after the holidays.



Table 4: Workshops and Presentations

Title	Venue	Date/Location	Attendees
Four New Online Training Modules on Employer Engagement Coming Your Way!	National Council on Rehabilitation Education (NCRE) Conference	November 5, 2020 Virtual	60
Four New Online Training Modules on Employer Engagement Coming Your Way!	National Rehabilitation Association (NRA) Conference	October 17, 2025	50
Top 10 Ways to Be Effective in Employer Engagement and Support Retention and Advancement	VRTAC on Quality Employment: QE National Symposium on Rehabilitation Counseling	June 2023 Madison, WI	60+
Employer Engagement and Ethical Considerations: Using an Ethical Decision-Making Model to Evaluate Dilemmas	14th Annual Summit on Performance Management	August 28, 2023 Burlington, VT	15
Operationalizing the Dual-Customer Approach: Emerging Models for Employment Success	Disability Employment Summit - National Rehabilitation Association	March 13, 2024 Virtual	25
Stronger Together: Innovative Employer Engagement through Meaningful Partnerships	VRTAC on Quality Employment: QE National Symposium on Rehabilitation Counseling	May 23, 2024 Madison, WI	114
Training-on-Demand: Session #1: Identifying, establishing, & expanding community partnerships for Employer Engagement	CT Aging & Disability Services Bureau of Rehabilitation Services	April 29, 2024 Hartford, CT Half day virtual session	25
Training-on-Demand: Session #2: Strategies for Building Long-Term Relationships with Employers	CT Aging & Disability Services Bureau of Rehabilitation Services	June 24, 2024 Half day in-person session	20
Training-on-Demand: Session #3: Strategies for Building Long-Term Relationships with Employers	CT Aging & Disability Services Bureau of Rehabilitation Services	June 24, 2024 Hartford, CT Half day in-person session	20
Training-on-Demand: Session #4: Communication Skills for Effective Employer Engagement	CT Aging & Disability Services Bureau of Rehabilitation Services	August 19, 2024 Half day virtual session	25
Pre-Apprenticeships: Individualized, Creative Workforce Development	Consortia of Administrators for Native American Rehabilitation (CANAR) Conference	June 3-5, 2025 Spokane, WA	9
Training-on-Demand: Business Engagement Opportunities & Strategies for Tribal Vocational Rehabilitation Projects & Staff	Mississippi Band of Choctaw Indians AIVR	April 29-May 1, 2025 Biloxi, MS 3 day in-person session	9
Training-on-Demand: Business Engagement Opportunities & Strategies for Tribal Vocational Rehabilitation Projects and Staff	The Navajo Nation AIVR	November 19-20, 2025 Albuquerque, NM 2 day in-person session	19



The CoP model and capstone projects further reinforced learning by encouraging participants to apply concepts in their work settings. Although participation in CoPs decreased over time, those who engaged reported positive outcomes, including improved employer relationships and innovative strategies for meeting business needs.

By Year 6, PIRTEE established a sustainable training framework that includes virtual and online delivery options; comprehensive curricula; and companion guides for leadership, supervisors, faculty, and trainers. These resources ensure that the impact of PIRTEE extends beyond individual learners to systemic improvements in employer engagement practices nationwide.

Evaluation Data

Summary of Trainees

As part of the program's evaluation, the Module 1 pre-test included a brief section asking training participants about their prior work experience and self-reported knowledge about employer engagement. This section was fielded only for Module 1 to describe the training cohort. Aggregated across all training cohorts, a total of N = 746 individual responses were collected for the "About You" questions fielded to trainees. Response distributions were relatively consistent when compared across cohorts as well as modes of training. The following section provides an overview of trainee responses and also includes qualitative information provided by trainees as part of the evaluation.

About a quarter of training participants indicated that they had received some employer engagement training post-WIOA and over half had not, while others were not sure.

Many of the participants reported having previous training through their employer (at their current or past positions), especially following the changes resulting from WIOA. Some participants had received training in employer engagement through their degree programs. Others said they had completed previous trainings through organizations such as the Institute for Community Inclusion (ICI), the Department of Labor, the Department of Human Services, and the Association of Community Rehabilitation Educators (ACRE).

Individuals that participated in iGREET had a wide range of previous experience, including many with some background in business.

Previous ICI research had found that some VR agencies employ business-facing staff who have a business background and may not have a counseling background. However, some VR agencies encourage or expect individuals in rehabilitation counseling roles to be proficient in employer engagement. iGREET participants had a range of backgrounds and responsibilities: 45% had a business background, 23% were Certified Rehabilitation Counselors (CRCs), and typically less than 10% of each cohort was serving as the state VR agency National Employment Team (NET) single point of contact.

For those who indicated having a business background, some had worked for a private corporation, small business, or had a sales background. Others had experience starting or owning a business, working in human resources (HR) or public relations, managing nonprofits, or held a business degree.

Table 5. Percentage of Trainees with Business Backgrounds

Business Background: Check all that apply	% of Trainees
Worked for a small business	25%
Worked for a private corporation	23%
Sales background	19%
Started a business	15%
Non-profit management	14%
Business owner	13%
Member of a Chamber of Commerce	12%
Background in HR	12%
Earned a business degree	11%
Background in public relations	8%



Individuals that participated in iGREET had a range of self-reported level of knowledge of employer engagement.

When asked to describe their level of knowledge about employer engagement prior to the training, participants rated themselves on a 4-point scale ranging from “beginner” to “expert.” The most frequently reported responses were “intermediate” (37%) and “beginner” (36%), while some reported their level of knowledge as “advanced” (21%) or “expert” (2%). Four percent were not sure.

Note: It was not clear if self-rated level of knowledge was consistently correlated with performance on pre-post tests of knowledge items.

Training evaluation data collected after the modules provided additional insights to the ways trainees viewed their knowledge of employer engagement before and after the training. Many individuals noted in their open-ended feedback that they were new to their business-facing positions or roles, while others said they had some experience, but this training helped them refine their knowledge and skills.

Overall, individuals with a range of knowledge of employer engagement found value in the training, including those new to the role and those with a more extensive background.

Training participants described the impact of the training in the following comments:

- » *I am new to employer engagement. This training is providing me with a solid foundation for future use.*
- » *This training reaffirmed much of what I already know, regarding business engagement; thus, collaboration with Workforce Development Boards, stakeholders, and the business community is key to long term successes.*
- » *The training allowed for me to attain additional insight on how to engage with employers, allowed for me to learn new tactics, and allowed for me to learn of current updates.*
- » *The training enhanced my knowledge of different business models, strategies, and opportunities for partnerships as well as the importance of language and cultural humility and the consideration of ethics in all that I do.*
- » *Although I have 30 years of HR experience, as a recently employed Job Placement Counselor with DARS I found that this training was an excellent orientation to my new position and helped me clarify the dual-customer approach.*
- » *It reinforced the things I am doing and gave me additional tools to use.*
- » *As a new placement counselor, it was helpful to understand the history, terms, partners, & processes involved in working with VR and especially how to describe to employers.*
- » *This training increased my knowledge base and understanding and gave me some great tools to utilize when working with businesses. With the current labor force issues, knowing about the tools for CIE makes me feel like I can really provide valuable services to my businesses.*

Table 6. Trainees Self-Reported Level of Knowledge of Employer Engagement Pre-Training

Level of Knowledge	% of Trainees
Expert	2%
Advanced	21%
Intermediate	37%
Beginner	36%
Not sure	4%
Total	100%



Summary of Pre-Post Knowledge Gains

Across all cohorts that engaged in the iGREET modules, some knowledge items consistently demonstrated increases as measured by pre-post tests. These knowledge items included both true/false and multiple-choice questions. Each module had 3-5 items with consistent positive gains on pre-post scores. Additionally, the evaluation survey fielded after each module included open-ended questions that yielded rich qualitative data. The following sections includes key knowledge questions and thematic summaries of qualitative data supplemented with direct quotes from trainees for each module.

Module 1

Foundations of Employer Engagement had the following objectives:

1. Recognize the importance of the dual-customer approach and how it applies to VR.
2. Identify the advantages of employer engagement to employers and job seekers.
3. Review the Certified Rehabilitation Counselors (CRC) Code of Ethics
4. Explore the strategies we can use to ensure ethical employer engagement.
5. Identify appropriate use of language as well as strategies on using “business-speak,” rather than “agency-speak.”
6. Identify methods for collecting, reporting, and sharing data on employer engagement activities.
7. Initiate business contacts and use labor market information to direct employer engagement connections.
8. Effectively communicate with employers, starting with initial contacts, and progressing through a developing relationship.

The pre-post knowledge gains and comments provided by trainees demonstrate that Module 1 training met the learning objectives, particularly around language and communication with businesses, as trainees considered strategies for reaching out to employers, cultivating relationships, and breaking down barriers.

Q. The dual - customer strategy implies that you must treat both customers equally at all times.

True

False

Trainees learned about approaching and maintaining connections with employers.

One trainee described the dual-customer approach: *“That we are trying to cultivate relationships to convince employers that persons with disabilities are employable, an asset, and are valuable, while recognizing the value of the business, by trying to ensure that the disabilities and varying manifestation match the position.”* Others noted insights around the nuances of employer engagement from the early stages of outreach to building relationships:

- » *While I am pretty well-versed on establishing new business, meeting potential employers, and creating/sharing an elevator pitch, I found the resources from this first module to be very helpful and highly engaging. It gave new ideas on how to approach certain situations and provided great tools to help me in establishing new business to approach down the line.*



- » *It provided insight into the importance of relationship building and appropriate steps to take when first working with a business*
- » *I learned valuable communication, language, and how to show expertise without arrogance.*
- » *I think it helped to break down the barriers of some of the ways we can get worried about talking to employers and helping come up with an easier approach.*
- » *Learned tools, strategies, and guidelines to implement dual-customer relationships with clients and employers that benefit all parties involved that may lead to long lasting relationships with positive outcomes.*

Trainees noted several key take-aways around language, terminology, and jargon.

Q. Examples of Specialized Business terms include all EXCEPT the following:

Company Footprint

Leveraging

Sort Observation

Warm Call

Eligibility

As demonstrated in the pre-post knowledge question here, the iGREET introduced the concept of specialized business terms to highlight the differences in “business-speak,” rather than “agency-speak.” This resonated with many trainees, as described in their comments:

- » *Using business terminology, because words matter.*
- » *I will try to remember to keep in mind the business contacts’ perspective in my communications, minimizing the use of our jargon and getting them the information they need in a clear and articulate way.*
- » *I will apply the knowledge I’ve gained by ensuring using language that resonates with whom I am communicating with and I will ensure to maintain ethical engagement by maintaining client autonomy and justice.*
- » *I now recognize the importance of using terminology that is easy to understand for professionals who don’t work in VR settings.*
- » *It illustrated the benefit of tactful communication with potential employers---being sure to use “business friendly” terminology.*
- » *I am now more aware of the vocabulary needed to interact with other employers.*





Although it was not specified as a learning objective, the Module 1 training resulted in knowledge gains around WIOA measures and indicators.

Q. Each core partner under WIOA has separate and distinct performance measures for employer engagement.

True

False

Q. Which of these options is NOT a WIOA state performance indicator?

a. Retention with the same employer

b. Satisfaction of the employer customer

c. Repeat business customers

d. Employer retention rates

Trainee comments included:

- » *The training assisted me in a better understanding of WIOA.*
- » *It gave me a better understanding of WIOA and the relationships that need to be developed.*
- » *Enhanced WIOA knowledge for job performance.*
- » *It gave me insight on the WIOA.*

There were also several specific skills or resources that trainees found actionable and relevant from Module 1. This included the “elevator pitch” concept, the Individualized Business Plan (IBP) tool, and strategic use of labor market information (LMI).

Q. To make a good first impression, it is important for an “elevator pitch” to consist of all of the information you want a business to know about you and your agency.

True

False

- » *I think being able to create an elevator pitch that will leave the discussion open is something I will try to do better.*
- » *It is very seldom that [we] conduct employer engagement. The training taught me the importance of an elevator speech. I’ve always thought to have one for when I was job seeking. Never realized how helpful one could be when attempting to make connections with employers.*
- » *The feedback about making elevator speeches was helpful, as well as tailoring the approach differently to each employer and just listening to needs initially.*
- » *As noted, my elevator pitch is better developed. Also, I recognize the importance of being well prepared before approaching business partners in the community.*



Module 2

Developing & Maximizing Partnership for Employer Engagement had the following objectives:

1. Identify possible strategic partnerships that are customized to the goals of the agency and/or employer .
2. Consider ways to include CRPs in the agency's employer engagement development and ensure they understand the agency's employer engagement messaging and marketing.
3. Demonstrate understanding of laws and regulations that affect employment for people with disabilities.
4. Identify training opportunities for employers that may be provided by their agency.
5. Identify benefits of various messaging approaches and materials for employer engagement.
6. Understand the elements and stages in the progression to partnership.
7. Recognize available partner stakeholders for employer engagement.
8. Identify work-based learning activities and describe the benefits to businesses and job seekers.
9. Use recognition and appreciation methods to enhance business partnerships.

The pre-post knowledge gains and comments provided by trainees demonstrate that Module 2 training impacted trainees knowledge and understanding of the VR system and how an employer may view it, as well as how partnerships with CRPs impact employer engagement. Additionally, trainees noted increased understanding of laws and regulations. Lastly, the importance of building trust in business partnerships was commonly cited as a key knowledge gain.

Q. The VR agency's three models for employer engagement are

Centralized, National, and Networked

Direct Service, Networked, and Local

Centralized, Regional, and Direct Service

The iGREET improved participants' understanding of the VR system:

- » *A good introduction to history of VR services.*
- » *It helped increase my scope from a VR perspective, since I come from a recruiting background.*
- » *It was relevant because I am new to it is helping me learn all the processes of the organization.*
- » *Although I have 30 years HR experience in private industry and "was the employer", this training is enabling me to see the partnership from both sides and is helping me to understand why VR services can add value and be a positive impact on the business, especially in the current climate where ready-to-work applicants are scarce.*
- » *It helps me to understand an employer's view of VR.*



Trainees learned how Individual Business Plans could be used to tailor their services to business' specific needs.

Q. Using employer engagement _____ can help employer engagement representatives develop an Individualized Business Plan (IBP) that addresses an employer's needs and readiness.

Skills Inventory

Data

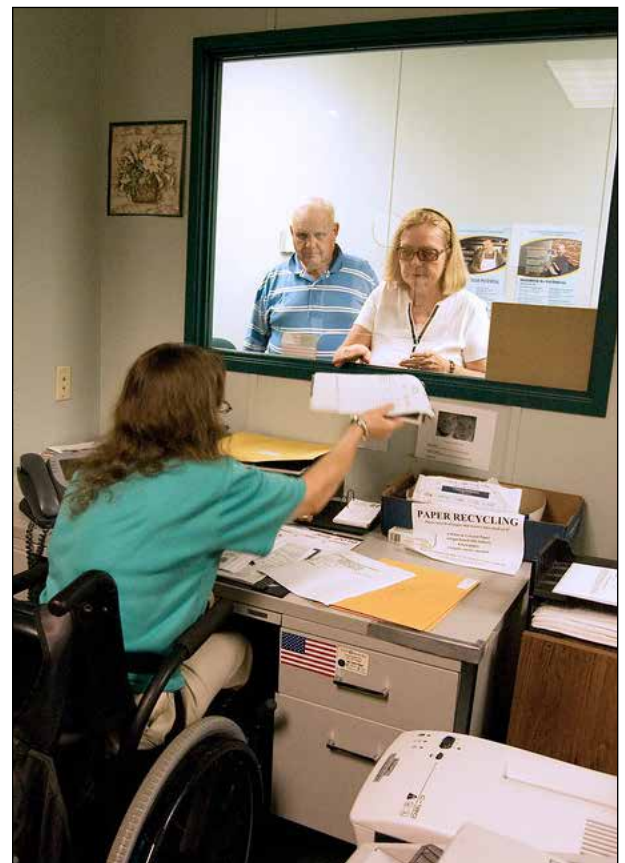
Funding Cycles

None of the above

- » *I will use the environmental and challenging situations approach and the IBP plan.*
- » *Learned new concepts about employer engagement. I was not familiar at all with the IBP.*
- » *[I will] consider how to assist consumers with developing their own IBP and labor market information assignments.*
- » *I am excited about the process for developing long- and short-term individualized business plans with businesses.*
- » *I plan on working with businesses that our office has experienced success, to develop IBP that lead to long term job opportunities.*

Trainees improved ability to understand and connect with other providers:

- » *I can now apply what I have learned about partnering with employers, working closely with the Workforce System, and utilizing the CRPs for services.*
- » *Helpful reminders on the various ways we can partner with outside resources and the benefits of this.*
- » *Increase collaboration with CRPs.*
- » *Increase communication with WIOA partners.*
- » *This training was relevant because I am starting to build employer relationships and this showed me the importance of utilizing our partners to strengthen those employer relationships.*
- » *This module made me realize the need to reach out and work with other agencies*
- » *Increased my knowledge of how to engage with other agencies and work together for our individuals.*
- » *How to work collaboratively with CRPs and utilize other organizations or resources in my area for business engagement.*





Trainees demonstrated increased understanding of laws and regulations that affect employment for people with disabilities.

Q. State workers' compensation programs do not have any federal oversight, mandates, or standards.

True

False

- » *Really helpful info on labor laws, workers comp, and partnering with other agencies.*
- » *Need to be aware of state and federal laws.*
- » *Also providing the laws and sections will allow me to be better prepared to discuss possibilities with employers and administration.*

Trainees also commented that improving listening skills could improve their ability to build trusting business relationships.

Q. According to research by Zenger and Folkman, which of these factors is the most important in building trust?

Consistency

Judgement and expertise

Relationships

- » *We will approach the employers in a different manner and ask what their needs are and if they would like to have a way to try and fill their needs as well as help open doors and offer experience to individuals with disabilities.*
- » *...[A]pplying the knowledge when conducting business engagement. I now feel that I do not have to say much when saying the right thing to employers. Listen more and speak less!*
- » *I will use the dual-customer approach and making connections with businesses to identify their needs and develop a plan to assist them as well as keeping the job seeker in mind and matching job seekers to businesses.*
- » *When meeting with employers will focus on employer needs more and will look for other opportunities within the business.*
- » *It helped with correlating VR language to business language and also drilled in the point that first contact is not about selling services. It is about learning what the needs of the business are.*
- » *I like how it talks about listening to employers as the primary means of forming a relationship. I think that can be a useful strategy.*



Module 3

Strategic and Individualized Employer Engagement had the following objectives:

1. Improve understanding of the standards of ethical attitudes and behaviors as an employment engagement professional.
2. Understand methods and tools for ethical decision-making in employer engagement.
3. Explore and resolve employer engagement scenarios in which ethical principles are applicable.
4. Apply LMI to identify different types of business (e.g., by size, sectors, for profit/not for profit, government contractors, government) to inform employer engagement
5. Identify characteristics of the varying types of employers to inform your approach to engagement.
6. Identify the range of entry points to access the business and establish relationships.
7. Identify employer engagement strategies relevant to a variety of different business cultures.
8. Determine strategies for adjusting employer engagement practices in response to environmental and economic challenges.
9. Recognize ways that you can identify and respond to unethical or legally questionable employer practices.

"I will meet with employer to develop individualized business plans to meet their needs along with the needs of qualified individuals. Developing a good relationship and plan is helpful for businesses to see how our services may impact their bottom line.."

—Training Participant

The pre-post knowledge gains and comments provided by trainees demonstrate that Module 3 training impacted trainees understanding of how cultural factors and varying types of businesses can impact the approach to employer engagement. The ethical considerations were also frequently noted by trainees, as was the Community Mapping exercise in Module 3.

Q. Which option is NOT an important reason to research and understand cultural considerations when approaching businesses?

Culture can encompass many factors beyond race and ethnicity

Understanding and respecting the businesses' cultures is important in forming relationships with employers

Business culture is an important element in helping job seekers find the right fit

It is best practice to always match job seekers and businesses with the same cultural background



Building upon knowledge gained in Module 2 around increasing listening skills, one trainee noted a change in their behavior, stating: *“I will ask more questions of the employer/business rather than first telling them what VR can do.”* Other trainees commented specifically on the importance of cultural considerations, especially when considering the match between employer and employee. Examples included:

- » *Engaging employers encompasses many facets. Many considerations need to be made when working with employers and having successful partnerships, including cultural and environmental considerations.*
- » *I will research business culture to make sure that the business is the right fit for my consumer.*
- » *I will increase my consideration of cultural diversity within businesses as a major factor. I will follow up more regularly with my business contacts.*
- » *I gained a lot of knowledge on the importance of the dual-customer approach in building lasting relationships with employers. The importance of research to learn about employers before actual outreach how culture plays a part in effective approached to employers and job seekers.*
- » *It gave me direction on who to talk with in finding out the culture of a business so I can fit the right employee into a position.*

The Community Mapping exercise in Module 3 was particularly useful for trainees, and many pointed out the benefits of this approach.

- » *Community mapping exercise - I will use it to approach employers with more confidence and to direct what topics I need more training on to better connect with employers (tax incentives, laws, etc.) .*
- » *I really enjoyed the Community Mapping. Never looked at Job Development that way and it was great to see more of what is in my own backyard. When I drive, I am now more aware, while still focusing on my driving. I had a lot of fun doing it and even researching on the Internet.*
- » *Approach businesses in the mapping project that were developed and opened during the pandemic. Will refine my elevator pitch.*

Q. It may be legal for a business to say they hire only people who are part of their religious denomination.

True

False

Trainees commented on the ethics of employer engagement:

- » *Learned from the code of ethics section. This was new to me.*
- » *Finally, I like the focus on the ethical issues and the discussion on how to deal with them.*
- » *I'm a CRC. It reminded me of the code of ethics. In my everyday work I always believe that I am acting ethically. The training was good because it reminded me that not everything is ethical.*



Trainees reported learning different ways to apply labor market information:

- » Utilize and dig “deeper” for LMI.
- » Use new LMI resources to make better job seeker and employer matches.
- » Look at the current LMI and see how this new information can impact our approach and needs to enhance placement opportunities to the participant while serving the business sector.
- » I will use this training content by building on existing businesses relationships, and by expanding into new businesses relationships that are tied to labor market information in the community.
- » LMI and use of sector information to identify employers and services engaged, as well as use of business plans to better plan/strategize future services was helpful.
- » Will focus on LMI more to guide decisions related to work with both clients and employers; will be able to better plan and work with a focus with the LMI and business plans and awareness/sensitivity of factors such as cultural diversity, economic, and other environmental changes.

Trainees also found the economic/disaster planning topics useful.

Q. Which of these is /are the best way(s) to support employers during an economic downturn or recession?

Offer assistance with retraining or cross training employees with disabilities

Offer to develop a future pipeline of job candidates

Help them find resources about employment law regarding layoffs and the ADA protections enjoyed by employees with disabilities

Understand that their priorities may need to shift from investing in diversity to saving the business

All of the above

- » I will relay this information to our statewide business team on steps to take when emergencies arise. We will review our services we offer and keep them in mind on how we can support an employer during a crisis while staying within policy and ethical standards.
- » Work on a disaster plan with client.
- » I learned more about building a business and ways we can help employers in time of disasters.
- » How VR handles natural disasters was useful.
- » The part about environmental issues was very relevant as this is a huge issue in the area that I cover.
- » Will be more mindful on the services I can provide during an environmental emergency.
- » It gave me more insight on how to address employers in environmental concerns.



Module 4

Employment Models to Meet Employer Needs had the following objectives:

1. Understand the definition and importance of competitive integrated employment (CIE) as defined in the WIOA.
2. Appreciate the importance of relationships in building trust and opening doors .
3. Understand the business implications of Supported Employment, Customized Employment, and non-traditional employment options like contract work or temp-to-hire, and how they may be presented to employers
4. Outline the components of work-based learning activities .
5. Explain the overall Progressive Employment model and its benefits to clients and businesses.
6. Identify whether work-based-learning or the Progressive Employment model fits in specific scenarios .
7. Demonstrate understanding of apprenticeships and career pathways as dual-customer models.
8. Identify opportunities to engage employers in implementation of these programs.
9. Understand effective employer engagement strategies for building apprenticeship and career pathways programs.

“I will use the apprenticeship guide as this is a goal on our state plan in setting up a possible site. I also will use Progressive Employment options more with businesses.”
— Training Participant

“Pre-ETS info will definitely help me apply. I love the Progressive Employment approach I have always favored coordinating services. With Progressive, it is a team and coordinated effort of rehab professionals who meet to brainstorm ideas, leads and contacts.”
—Training Participant

The pre-post knowledge gains and comments provided by trainees demonstrate that Module 4 training impacted trainees understanding of Progressive Employment and other work-based learning opportunities. Comments suggested that participants learned a great deal about implementing apprenticeships, on-the-job training, and other work-based learning experiences.

Trainees improved their overall understanding of career pathways, including what employers needed to know.

Q. A Career Pathways approach rules out helping someone to get a job in an unrelated field for immediate income.

True

☒ False

Q. It is critical that employers be knowledgeable about the law that specifies Competitive Integrated Employment

True

☒ False



- » *It is helpful to think about the criteria for CIE. Also, it has inspired me to think more about opportunities for internships, apprenticeships, on the job learning opportunities, etc.*
- » *The training helped enhance my knowledge on current changes regarding WBLE [work-based learning experiences] and apprenticeships along with CIE.*
- » *I feel the concepts of WBL [work-based learning] add the most value as it provides real life work experiences that promote and support all that is dual employment. It's reality.*

Trainees gained an in-depth understanding of some of the specific components of work-based learning:

ON-THE-JOB TRAINING

Q. Research has found on - the job - training to be a highly effective tool, but it is one of the least used interventions in VR.

True

False

- » *This training identified some of the benefits of on-the-job training and other work readiness programs.*
- » *Ideas about possibilities for on-the-job training, internships, etc., rather than just focusing on straight job placement.*

PROGRESSIVE EMPLOYMENT

Q. Progressive employment does not require a linear progression from low - dose to high - dose work - based learning experiences.

True

False

- » *Pre-ETS [pre-Employment Transition Services] info will definitely help me apply. I love the Progressive Employment approach. I have always favored coordinating services. With Progressive, it is a team and coordinated effort of rehab professionals who meet to brainstorm ideas, leads, and contacts.*

REGISTERED APPRENTICESHIPS

Q. Which of these is a feature of apprenticeships and NOT internships?

Needs to be paid at least minimum wage

Needs to be eligible for the same benefits provided to other employees

Needs to be supported by a job coach

Affords the same opportunities for advancement as other employees



- » *Apprenticeships -- how to get an employer to at least consider this as a training opportunity.*
- » *This session focused more on apprenticeship programs and this is something our state doesn't do. I saved the apprenticeship guide for more information.*
- » *Develop new work-base[d] learning experiences and help employers identify apprenticeship opportunities.*
- » *I will use the apprenticeship guide as this is a goal on our state plan in setting up a possible site. I also will use Progressive Employment options more with businesses.*
- » *It improved by understanding of apprenticeship and work-based learning services that will improve my job skills.*

GOAL 4: TRAINING TO SUPERVISORS, LEADERSHIP, AND TRAINING DIRECTORS

Provide training to supervisors, leadership, and training directors to improve VR's capacity to engage employers through adoption of evidence-based practices and strategies.

Table 7: Corresponding Status Chart Performance Data

Status Chart #2 measures a-j Performance Data			
Leadership			
Performance Measure	Measure Type	Target	Actual Performance
Number of individuals enrolled in the training for leadership	Program	80	138
Number of individuals who successfully complete the training	Program	80	105
The quality of the training developed, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	90.7%
The relevance of the training developed, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	87.1%
The usefulness of the training developed, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	81.7%
Supervisors			
Performance Measure	Measure Type	Target	Actual Performance
Number of individuals enrolled in the training for supervisors	Program	80	205
Number of individuals who successfully complete the training	Program	80	152
The quality of the training developed, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	93.6%
The relevance of the training developed, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	97.9%
The usefulness of the training developed, as measured by a panel of VR agencies	GPRA	80%	88.3%
Training Directors			
Performance Measure	Measure Type	Target	Actual Performance
Number of individuals enrolled in the training for T-CoP	Program	25	52
Number of individuals who successfully complete the T-CoP	Program	25	37

*Individuals who participated in the T-CoP were required to complete the online iGREET course. Therefore, they completed the training evaluation and their responses to the program and GPRA measures were reported in Goal #3.



Overview and Alignment to Purpose

Goal 4 of the PIRTEE project focuses on providing targeted training for VR agency leadership, supervisors, and trainers to ensure effective implementation and sustainability of employer engagement practices. This goal aligns with the project's purpose of embedding employer engagement strategies into organizational structures and policies, supporting staff development, and promoting systemic change. The approach includes specialized sessions for leadership and supervisors, as well as a Train-the-Trainer model supported by a Community of Practice (T-CoP). These efforts aim to build internal capacity within agencies to deliver and reinforce the iGREET curriculum, ensuring long-term impact beyond the life of the grant.

Major Activities and Accomplishments

The project developed, delivered, and continuously refined a national, multi-modal training program that substantially increased VR professionals' capacity to engage employers. By offering high-quality virtual instruction, accessible online modules, targeted in-person workshops, and sustained CoPs, the PIRTEE project ensured broad reach and meaningful learning outcomes. Moreover, the establishment of a Train-the-Trainer model and the creation of companion guides laid a strong foundation for continued dissemination and long-term sustainability. Through this work, VR agencies across the country gained knowledge, tools, and strategies that directly support improved employment outcomes for individuals with disabilities.

Leadership/Supervisor Training

The project team developed and delivered multiple training sessions tailored to leadership and supervisors, focusing on the content and application of the iGREET modules. Leadership sessions emphasized strategic vision, infrastructure, and resource allocation to support employer engagement, while supervisor sessions addressed practical strategies for guiding staff and improving outcomes. Each session incorporated interactive elements, such as case discussions, networking opportunities, and self-assessment exercises.

The content for leadership and supervisor trainings drew from all four iGREET modules: 1) Foundations of Employer Engagement, 2) Developing and Maximizing Partnerships, 3) Strategic and Individualized Employer Engagement, and 4) Employment Models to Meet Employer Needs. Sessions highlighted ethical considerations, business relations unit structure, and agency infrastructure considerations and strategies for integrating employer engagement into agency policies and practices. Feedback from participants informed revisions to companion guides and training materials, ensuring relevance and usability.

The PIRTEE initially proposed a combined leadership and supervisor training. However, CAT and other VR staff recommended that each target group, VR Leadership and VR Supervisors, have their own training. As with the virtual training modules, group size was capped to allow for an interactive experience. The Leadership session was capped at 50 and the Supervisor session at 30. The training objectives were as follows:

Upon completion of the training, administrators were expected to:

- » become familiar with content of iGREET modules to determine appropriate use of the curriculum within the VR agency
- » evaluate the agency's current vision, structures, and supports for implementation of a productive Business Services/Employer Engagement program
- » network with other VR agency leaders to share strategies and resources for employer engagement



Upon completion of the training, supervisors were expected to:

- » become familiar with content of iGREET modules to determine appropriate staff/self-participation
- » assess personal supervisory practices that support employer engagement and staff effectiveness
- » consider additional approaches to support participant employment outcomes
- » network with other VR agency supervisors to share strategies and resources for employer engagement

Training participants were from 23 state VR agencies; one AIVR program; eight CRPs across 25 states; and one WIOA partner, such as America Job Center, Developmental Disability Agencies, Veteran Health Administration and Veteran Affairs.

Two examples in the following Impact Story demonstrate that agency administrators found the iGREET content of value and accessed a number of the trainings for themselves and their staff.

Impact Story: VR Leadership Embraces the iGREET Training Series

Washinton Department of Services for the Blind (DSB)

Michael McCallup, Director of the Washington Department of Services for the Blind (DSB) attended the iGREET leadership training to see what, if anything, needed to be done or encouraged at his agency to promote best practices in employer engagement. After attending the leadership overview training and reviewing the Leadership Companion Guide, he decided to enroll in the online iGREET. Upon completion of both trainings, he returned to his agency and communicated the value and quality of the training to his team. The agency subsequently enrolled many of their staff in the online and virtual iGREET.

The Mississippi Band of Choctaw Indians Vocational Rehabilitation Services Program

Similarly, Director of the Tribal VR Agency for the Band of Choctaw Indians Mary Maruvia participated in numerous aspects of the iGREET, along with her co-director. They actively participated in virtual training, the T-CoP, and leadership training. She ultimately requested that Training-on-Demand be brought to Mississippi to enroll her staff and make it available to other Tribal VR agencies in her region. Through their participation in these various iGREET activities, they have proactively implemented an employer engagement focus within their VR program and are defining themselves even further as a workforce agency with a dual-customer focus.

Train-the-Trainer (T-CoP)

A significant component of Goal 4 was the development of VR agencies' internal training capacity. The Train-the-Trainer Community of Practice (T-CoP) prepared VR training staff to deliver iGREET internally, provided a structured facilitation guide, and supported implementation projects. Participants in the T-CoP demonstrated strong commitment, and many completed capstones that translated knowledge into applied practice. The T-CoP also played a key role in shaping the trainer guides and ensuring the curriculum could be sustainably delivered post-grant.

Based on CAT recommendations, PIRTEE moved away from a static "Train-the-Trainer" workshop to a dynamic T-CoP. This group, composed of VR training directors and managers, met regularly to:

- » learn the iGREET curriculum in depth
- » develop state-specific implementation plans
- » share resources for internal staff development
- » enroll their own agency staff in the online modules



Trainer Community of Practice (T-CoP) Recruitment and Launch: A national recruitment effort sought individuals to serve as future trainers of the iGREET content. Recruitment activities also extended beyond immediate training needs to support sustainability. The project proactively recruited participants for the T-CoP to build a pipeline of facilitators capable of delivering iGREET internally within their agencies. This included identifying individuals with strong facilitation skills, supporting them through a structured capstone process, and ensuring representation from diverse state VR systems. This built capacity for sustained training beyond the project period, ensuring that the capacity to teach iGREET remains within the agencies after 2025.

The T-CoP recruitment plan identified VR agency training staff as the primary audience for the Train-the-Trainer Companion Guide. The PIRTEE conducted extensive outreach to VR training directors (through CSAVR, National Council of State Agencies for the Blind (NCSAB), the Clearinghouse, and the George Washington University Training Director CoP), explaining that the intent of the group was to promote the use of the training modules in their agencies, but the majority of those that registered were business engagement staff. Participants were encouraged to connect with their training staff and ask them to join the training with them.

Training participants were from 12 state VR agencies, one AIVR program, and one CRP across 14 states. Participants completed the online modules and implemented a capstone project. The capstone required that they recruit staff to participate in the online iGREET. The second component of their capstone was for T-CoP members to create supplemental training, facilitate group discussions, and support implementation of employer engagement strategies. The members engaged in monthly T-CoP meetings to share experiences, troubleshoot challenges, and refine training plans. Capstone projects required trainers to enroll staff in the iGREET online modules and conduct supplemental sessions using the Trainer Companion Guide.

Some of the T-CoP members opened their capstone training to agencies outside of their VR agency. For example, one agency invited CRP staff. Other T-CoP members are exploring the possibility of including other WIOA partners in the training. Additional resources, including templates, discussion prompts, and a dedicated webpage, were provided to support trainers. Capstone projects required in the Train-the-Trainer model proved highly successful and demonstrated participants' ability to apply strategies in real service settings.

Outcomes and Impact

The leadership and supervisor trainings enhanced participants' understanding of employer engagement principles and their role in fostering a supportive organizational environment. Leaders reported increased confidence in evaluating agency structures and identifying opportunities for improvement, while supervisors gained practical tools for coaching staff and promoting effective practices. The interactive format facilitated peer learning and the exchange of strategies across agencies.

The Train-the-Trainer model and T-CoP created a sustainable framework for ongoing professional development. Trainers successfully implemented capstone projects, enrolling staff in online modules and facilitating follow-up discussions to reinforce learning. This approach not only expanded the reach of the iGREET curriculum but also empowered agencies to maintain training efforts independently. Feedback from T-CoP participants highlighted the value of collaborative problem-solving and resource sharing, contributing to stronger employer engagement practices statewide.

By Year 5, PIRTEE had finalized companion guides for leadership, supervisors, faculty, and trainers, consolidating content into user-friendly formats. These guides, combined with the training sessions and T-CoP activities, established a comprehensive support system for integrating



employer engagement strategies into VR agency operations. The impact of Goal 4 extends beyond individual participants to systemic improvements, positioning agencies to sustain and evolve their business engagement efforts in alignment with WIOA mandates.

Impact Story: The Mississippi Band of Choctaw Indians Vocational Rehabilitation Services Program

iGREET has been used by several agencies through various avenues to meet the needs of staff at multiple levels. For example, the Choctaw Tribal VR agency started their involvement by the director of the agency participating in a virtual iGREET course, actively engaging in discussions, and considering how the content could apply and support the work of her counseling and employment specialist staff. From there, she and her assistant director attended the T-CoP so they could use the online, asynchronous course and the iGREET Trainer Companion Guide to facilitate internal agency employer engagement conversations and business engagement development. The Choctaw TVR agency also invited ICI to present an in-person iGREET course specifically for eastern region TVR agency staff, which included a partnership with the American Indian Vocational Rehabilitation Training and Technical Assistance Center (AIVRTTAC). Staff from the AIVRTTAC co-presented with ICI staff to answer questions directly related to AIVR policies, guidelines, and cultural practices. This example demonstrates how the range of products and services within the PIRTEE project was able to support the development and advancement of employer engagement practices for management, business-facing staff, and community partner agencies.

Evaluation Data

Trainees completing the leadership and supervisory trainings were invited to participate in the program evaluation survey at the end of the training. In addition to the closed-ended rating questions of quality, relevance, and usefulness, training participants provided open-ended qualitative input on those key performance measures. The next section includes a brief summary of themes that emerged in participant responses and supporting quotations from trainees in the supervisory and leadership cohorts.

Supervisory Training

Respondents felt that the training provided further understanding and insight into employer engagement.

- » *The training provided information on effective employer engagement techniques and strategies.*
- » *I am new to my position and taking this training was very helpful. The ‘culture aspect’ of business is what I learned that was new. I think I have not thought about the cultural piece of the business.*
- » *It made me view things differently and want to really engage more with the employers vs just the employees who deal with employers.*
- » *I knew we needed strong support toward EE [employer engagement], and some help with a developed pathway to get there (naturally, ICI). This introduction to the training was specific and well-delivered enough to give a clear picture of how it would happen. It identified practical as well as theoretical material to focus on, to be*



quickly applicable and effective. I do hope the modules include some how-to training/teaching approaches related to elements of the Manager's Toolkit and the Business Engagement Toolkit.

- » *I'm new in my role as business relations specialist for my office and the discussions with staff on the topic and throughout the states were very helpful, especially learning about the special programming.*
- » *As an apprenticeship navigator with VR, I need to develop strong skills in employer engagement. This training was a good introduction to the modules and helped me understand how the modules are relevant to my role.*
- » *We need to strengthen our connections to the businesses and employers communities we serve to help them fill their needs with appropriate clients. This seemed to be a more comprehensive training curriculum than what our staff currently receive in trainings.*

A few respondents specifically mentioned learning about some new areas.

- » *The NET and TAP [Talent Acquisition Portal] were both new to me and our team, so I will pass that information along to my team.*
- » *I am more aware of Labor laws and how to handle potential employers who are not as informed about Labor laws.*
- » *Training was very good in that it gave ideas for me to use and for staff to use, such as using labor market information, work tax credit, ADA, and employment laws in developing those relationships with employers.*

Respondents discussed how they could use the information to better reinforce the work their staff does.

- » *We are a small Tribal VR Agency. As Program Directors we must wear many hats. Reminding me of the RSA-funded training for staff was crucial. Our job placement counselor position recently turned over. This individual is the primary responsible business engagement staff member; but all staff could benefit from the training.*
- » *More aware of importance and some ways to support, i.e., discuss/check in regularly on engagement in staff meetings*
- » *I felt like this training gave me a better perspective for my role on how I should be assisting my staff with being engaged with the community and the staff to provide valuable information and resources.*
- » *1) Follow with my staff about employers engagement. 2) Discuss when is appropriate to use unpaid work experiences, OJT, apprenticeships, temp to hire, etc.*

Participants also described some ways they planned to more completely integrate business engagement professionals into their teams or with other stakeholders.

- » *Have regular staffings with VRCs [VR counselors] so the BSR/BSC [business engagement staff] know what customers the VRC's have to fill the positions for the employers. Review open positions at each monthly staff meeting.*
- » *Have joint meetings with counselors and EE [employer engagement] staff and celebrate individual successes within our area.*
- » *I will have the business service unit come to the VR staff meetings monthly to provide input on their current work with employers and to answer any questions from VR counselors. I will have the VR counselor meet individually with the business service rep to get an insight on the job search of a mutual consumer.*



- » *Since I was a VR counselor, it reinforces my efforts in this role as a supervisor by listening to my local office team's concerns, training to understand policies/laws and procedures regarding similar situations discussed in the breakout meeting. It also show the need for both units to meet regularly. I have an open invite with the business specialist assigned to the region I work in so we can keep lines of communication open.*

Participants benefited from learning new methods and from hearing perspectives from other agencies.

- » *Some new methods were touched on within the module explanations and new ideas were discussed by peers across the country. It was interesting to hear what others are doing in their states.*
- » *It was eye open to me to learn from a variety of people from different States and agencies and also to compare the way how DOR in CA conducts business.*
- » *We work with employers everyday, just not in the same fashion other VR offices do. It was nice to learn how other offices are incorporating this.*

Other comments mentioned that the training was well-organized and appreciated the structure, such as receiving materials in advance. Participants found the breakout sessions particularly helpful as they involved real-world examples and interaction among trainees. A few respondents felt that the training was not what they expected, which is reflected in some respondents' ratings of the overall quality, relevance, and usefulness, for example:

- » *I got some overall information about business relations, but it was not really what I expected. I thought there would be more content, vs. just an overview of what the "real" training was about.*
- » *It was difficult for me to determine the purpose of the training--was it to pass knowledge on to me or was it to get me to sign my staff up for further trainings?*
- » *I think the advertising of this was misleading; would have liked this more if it was actual supervisor training.*
- » *OK, my fault for not reading closely... and didn't notice it was an overview of a training and not an actual training. How to I find info on the actual training?*
- » *Did not have any actual information, just an overview of a training.*

Leadership Training

Respondents commented that they benefited from the resources provided and from discussing these ideas with practitioners from other agencies.

- » *As a supervisor of staff who are put to the task of job development, it was helpful to hear from other agencies and what is considered best practice.*
- » *It was useful to hear how other states are operating and the challenges they face as well as their solutions.*
- » *It is valuable to hear what others are doing and what is working and what is providing challenges.*
- » *It was interesting to hear from other states how their business services are set up and the roles their staff play to provide services to employers.*
- » *The training gave me an opportunity to hear what's going on in the VR field and hear information with other state VR leaders.*
- » *I thought the training provided good discussion points to the group and allowed for sharing experiences when doing employer engagement and problem solving.*



Some participants commented that the training helped them understand and improve their infrastructure for employer engagement services.

- » *I feel I am better prepared to bring more ideas to my agency and team.*
- » *The training was sufficient for me to determine that it would benefit my agency in better developing employer engagement methods.*
- » *I will use internal resources and business engagement knowledge more than I did before. I will suggest and encourage vocational counselors to take some role in business engagement. Voc counselors have no business engagement role. VRCs [VR counselors] refer clients to CRPs and the business specialists. I will connect with and collaborate with CRPs more than I have been.*

Many participants commented that the training addressed policy needs in their agencies.

- » *This is in line with policy changes we need to make for our agency. There needs to be a greater understanding across all staff about the importance of getting people with disabilities into different work-based experiences, and not just pre-ETS [pre-Employment Transition Services] age consumers.*
- » *My agency needs to better develop our services to employers. This training was a thorough review of the available modules, which was very helpful.*
- » *There were ideas presented and discussed that impact our state much like others are experiencing. Specifically, the reporting systems in career centers and duplication of information each of us intake during our process.*

Participants commented that the training helped broaden their perspective on employer engagement issues at the leadership level.

- » *This training broadened my perspective to think from the employer's point of view and helped me understand what approaches to take with the employer/business.*
- » *It is a big topic of discussion internally in the agency. We are behind in developing our vision for business relations/engagement, and it is helpful to gather other experiences.*
- » *ND is currently working on employer engagement, and I have already shared the information with our leadership team.*
- » *Clarity of agency vision as it pertains to business engagement, and for structural changes as they occur are essential.*
- » *Highlighted the importance of supporting business engagement from the top down and providing tools and training to VR staff doing this work on the local level.*





Some participants commented that the training was too basic for their needs.

- » *I was excited about the training & was disappointed because I felt it was too basic. Additionally, I did not leave with anything new that I could use for my job.*
- » *The training was fundamental. Our organization may be further ahead than others in terms of our approach and partnerships. Would have liked to hear more replicable and innovative best practices on how to engage with business. Specifically, more on how organizations were leveraging partnerships with public workforce system partners to improve outcomes and performance with regard to business engagement, because WIOA.*
- » *The discussions about employer engagement has been something we have been doing for some time now. I feel we have a system that works, and is very successful, as it is measured and those measurements are shared throughout the state.*
- » *We are already doing an excellent job with structured employer outreach in VT.*
- » *The discussions we had are interesting, as it is something we, as an organization have been doing for a while now. I feel we are innovators.*

Some of the comments suggested that the leaders appreciated the opportunity to learn more about the information presented in the training and what their staff could be doing for employer engagement.

- » *Beginning to develop an employee engagement team and this information will help define onboarding, training, approaches, and documentation.*
- » *I am a district administrator in PA and any information that helps to provide support to customers and educating employer is always relevant.*
- » *Appreciated seeing what the modules cover that my staff are currently learning in the training.*
- » *I will continue to work with staff on employer engagement events and I will reach out to local employers to introduce and re-introduce our agency.*
- » *Communication is key, so continuing to share the vision to staff, and continuing the use of our database to share our communications with businesses, so other staff and partner agencies have access to that information.*

Similar to the supervisory training, a few participants felt that the training was not what they expected.

- » *I may have misunderstood the intended audience. I am a CEO of a CRP and felt the training was geared toward VR/DEED [Department of Employment and Economic Development] senior leaders. I was also disappointed when I thought I signed up for a training and instead of being given information on how to do something, we were being asked questions of how we are doing things.*
- » *Need a better description of the training.*
- » *I was surprised when we jumped right into asking the participants open ended questions at the very beginning. Maybe I missed it, but I was not prepared for this with my technology. And, I would have preferred a heads up about the questions that were going to be asked so I could have been more prepared with research into answers. It would have been more valuable to everyone if I could have shared Pennsylvania's information with other states. I think this sharing of information and successes/challenges is very valuable, but I was not prepared for it. Also, I didn't have my mic set up in a suitable location for interaction.*



GOAL 5: Evaluation

Conduct a rigorous, ongoing, and improvement-oriented evaluation to assess the quality, relevance, usefulness, and effectiveness of the iGREET employer engagement training, and use findings to refine and strengthen the curriculum and delivery.

PIRTEE employed a continuous quality improvement (CQI) approach to evaluate the training modules; refine them based on the evaluation outcomes; reevaluate the refined modules; provide guidance about effective strategies suitable for replication in other settings; and identify, track, and report on key program outcomes. Process measures were designed to improve ongoing development and continuing performance through feedback from periodic assessment. PIRTEE did the following:

1. Conducted evaluation of overall project operations and CAT to ensure project is meeting benchmarks and deliverables within project plan.
2. Conducted pre- and post-tests of learner knowledge, skills, competencies, satisfaction, and use in the field for each training.
3. Reviewed web analytics to determine usage, retention rates, flow through course, most used materials, and ease of use.
4. Provided quarterly and annual summary reports and made recommendations for changes to project operations and training as part of CQI.

Results for each training event (Goals 3–4) include the complete evaluation data organized by Government Performance and Results Act (GPRA) measures and criteria. *(Please note: The panel of VR agencies is defined as the training cohort that participated in the module training.)* Trainees represented a range of VR agencies nationwide, and the individuals held a range of staff positions. The CAT periodically reviewed the evaluation findings and provided input to the PIRTEE project team. The overall relevance, usefulness, and quality (see criterion (a)) is reported on the Project Status Charts. The targets set in the Project Status Chart by the project leads were that 80% of the panel of VR agencies rate the training as: high or somewhat high quality; very relevant or relevant; and very useful or useful.

As stated in the Notices Inviting Applications (NIA), Quality of the Project Evaluation (p. 32139), we evaluated the quality of the proposed training modules, refined the training modules based on the evaluation outcomes, and re-evaluated the refined training modules on an ongoing basis.

Overview and Alignment to Purpose

Developing Evaluation Mechanisms for Assessing the Quality, Relevance, and Usefulness of Training

In Year 1 of the project, the ICI evaluation team developed definitions and criteria to measure the quality, relevance, and usefulness of the training. Each criterion was rated on a 4-point Likert scale by a panel of VR agencies. Early in the project, the Curriculum Advisory Team (CAT) used these criteria to provide early feedback on the quality, relevance, and usefulness of the training content (prior to delivery to training cohorts). In Year 2, for the training modules, the panel of VR agencies was defined as the training cohort that participated in the module training. Trainees represented a range of VR agencies nationwide, and the individuals held a range of staff positions. The CAT periodically reviewed the evaluation findings and provided input to the PIRTEE project team.

The overall relevance, usefulness, and quality (see criterion (a)) is reported on the Project Status Charts. The targets set in the Project Status Chart by the project leads are that 80% of the panel of VR agencies rate the training as high or somewhat high quality, very relevant or relevant, and very useful or useful. To provide further detail, all measures are reported in this evaluation narrative for each individual training module. See Table 8.



Table 8. PIRTEE Training Evaluation GPRA Measures and Criteria

RELEVANCE		
Pertinent and applicable to employer engagement		
	Criterion	Measures
a	Please rate the overall relevance of the training	Likert (4 pt) Very Relevant—Not at all Relevant
b	The training content was based on current evidence in the field	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
c	The training content addressed a current need or issue	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
d	The training content presented met my expectations	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
e	Please describe how the training was relevant to you.	Open text
USEFUL		
The quality of having utility and practical value		
	Criterion	Measures
a	Please rate the overall usefulness of the training	Likert (4 pt) Very Useful—Not at all Useful
b	The training content and materials can be readily applied	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
c	The training balanced theoretical and practical material	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
d	The training increased my knowledge	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
e	Please describe how the training impacted your knowledge of employer engagement.	Open text
f	Please list two ways you will apply or use the training content in your job.	Open text
QUALITY		
Degree of excellence		
	Criterion	Measures
a	Please rate the overall quality of the training	Likert (4 pt) High Quality—Low Quality
b	The presenter(s) was informative	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
c	The presenter(s) was organized	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
d	The presenter(s) responded effectively to questions	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
e	The presenter(s) adequately covered the topic in the allotted time	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
f	The materials provided were accessible and clear	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
g	The materials provided increased the quality of the training	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree
h	The case studies improved the quality of the training	Likert (4 pt) Strongly Agree—Strongly Disagree





Major Activities and Accomplishments

Approach Using Pre- and Post-Tests for Assessing the Knowledge, Skills, and Competencies Gained among Trainees

The evaluation design included pre-post testing to measure knowledge gained because of the training. For each training module, the iGREET team developed a series of true/false and multiple-choice questions. The online training team programmed the pre- and post-tests into the Canvas LMS as part of the course design. The course administrators asked participants to answer the pre-test questions in the week prior to the course start date and then asked the same knowledge questions along with a brief evaluation when trainees completed each module. Trainees were required to complete the pre-test before accessing the module content. Then, at the end of each online module, trainees were required to pass the post-test, earning a score of 80% or better in three attempts before moving on to the next module. For the analysis presented in this report, we used data collected on the first attempt only.

The online course design also incorporated knowledge checks throughout the modules. These were unscored and data are not tracked; however, the knowledge checks may help participants to perform better on the post-test. Raw data were extracted from the Canvas learning management system administrator at the ICI and exported into excel files for analysis by the evaluation team.

Evaluation Implementation

The evaluation team consisted of a senior research associate/program manager and a research study coordinator who were responsible for designing instruments, developing quantitative and qualitative data collection tools, collecting progress data, and assessing project outcomes. For internal quality control, the research study coordinator prepared evaluation data and developed preliminary reports, and the senior research associate/program manager checked for accuracy and edited reports. The evaluation team also had access to peers and supervisors for additional support as needed.

To facilitate an objective evaluation, the ICI evaluation team operated independently from the curriculum team and was not involved in developing and/or providing training or in programmatic decision-making. The evaluation lead coordinated with the project directors (PI/Co-PI) and the Rehabilitation Services Administration (RSA) to make revisions to the evaluation design and instrumentation throughout the project.

Outcomes and Impact

Quality, Relevance, and Usefulness

“[The iGREET] provides real-world scenarios we come across every day in the field in working to serve our participants. It also helps us come up with new ideas for our work from what others have already tried and [are] successfully doing. It is a practical resource of information for us in working with our employers.”—Training Participant

Across all modules, cohorts, and types of training, the PIRTEE program consistently exceeded the target of 80% of trainees reporting the training modules as high quality, relevant, and useful.

Goals 3 and 4 included the key performance measures aggregated across training cohorts. As reported in the summary tables 3 and 4, the PIRTEE program consistently exceeded the target of 80% of trainees reporting the training modules as high quality, relevant, and useful, with most measures exceeding 90–95%. In addition to the closed-ended rating questions, training participants provided open-ended qualitative input on those key performance measures. The next section includes a brief summary and supporting quotations from trainees for each measure.



Quality: The training was overwhelmingly considered high quality, and trainees frequently commented that the training content was comprehensive, organized, and easy to follow.

For example:

- » *This was a high-quality training that was well organized and explained. The videos were helpful to see concepts in action.*
- » *Great training. Online portion was fantastic, better than expected. The real benefit comes from the group virtual sessions!*
- » *I find this training to be comprehensive and in line with the best practices I have learned in the field.*
- » *The training follows a logical order, is broken into small sections, and provides interaction as well. It has been a good course. Thank you.*
- » *Great tips and discussion of the process. Easily followed and understood. It has been many years since I have engaged in training on this topic.*
- » *As a former business owner who now works in VR, felt this training was very well done. The training covered all aspects of supporting employers with education and resources to expand opportunities for people with disabilities in the workforce.*
- » *All of the information was really very informative and helpful. I really appreciate the work and excellent effort put forth by the team. It was well thought out and very organized. I can honestly say that I gained something from each lesson from each module. I would definitely recommend this training to others. Keep up the great work!*
- » *The training contains some good practices for evaluating and researching prospective employers.*
- » *It was very insightful and I am learning a lot about what my position does within the government and the secular world.*

Relevance: Training participants found the training to be pertinent and applicable to their work.

The training helped many participants to solidify their understanding of employer engagement strategies and address current needs or issues. Comments included:

- » *It's a very strategic approach to business services that addresses best practices and challenges we may face. I really enjoy the videos within the training.*
- » *The training provides a very good understanding of the history of Workforce Innovation System Services communicated in a very clear manner. The training goes in depth about terminology that I was familiar with in a more detailed manner. The training is also relevant because it confirms some things that I am doing correctly, it shines a light on things that I can improve upon as well as learn new terminology and approaches I can implement in the near future.*
- » *Going out, talking to businesses, and making connections in the community, all serve the purpose of matching employers with talented job seekers.*
- » *It gave me a stronger foundation of employer engagement knowledge.*
- » *Supported the dual-customer approach by highlighting the importance of matching both job seeker and employer goals and focusing on the creation of a "long-term" relationship.*

Some trainees indicated that the content was not always relevant or actionable in the field.

- » *While it is good to know the history of VR, I would like more hands-on ways to apply it in the field when talking with employers.*



- » *The training was solid in a general sense. More detailed techniques and practices would be helpful.*
- » *The quality is good, and the ideas are good. In practice, there are more barriers.*

Usefulness: The training participants reported that the content had practical value and could be readily applied. Many participants also described how the training impacted both their knowledge and approach to employer engagement. For example:

- » *The information presented matches perfectly with my core job duties and performance measures.*
- » *It will be relied upon daily in my position.*
- » *It [The training] is integral to performing the position at a high level.*
- » *I work for a CRP. Business engagement is a struggle for our team, and this information helps to better understand the how and the why of business engagement.*
- » *My primary function at my job is to reach out to employers and build relationships. This training is spot-on.*
- » *I am preparing for an employment specialist position that our state will be opening hopefully next year so I am getting exposed to a lot of great information from around the country on how it is being done there.*
- » *As the business engagement representative for this office, the materials covered in this module were all relative and important in carrying out the responsibilities I've been assigned in a professional and meaningful manner.*
- » *Provided additional insight into my new career as a job placement counselor and how to partner with VR counselors, CRPs, employers, and customers.*

GOAL 6: COLLABORATION AND DISSEMINATION ACTIVITIES

Conduct additional effective collaboration and dissemination activities.

Overview and Alignment to Purpose

Goal 6 of the PIRTEE project focused on dissemination, collaboration, and sustainability planning to ensure that the iGREET series and associated resources reached a broad audience and remain accessible beyond the life of the grant. This goal aligned with the project's purpose of embedding employer engagement practices into VR systems nationwide by leveraging partnerships, marketing strategies, and knowledge translation tools. The KT and Marketing and Communication (M&C) teams worked collaboratively to create a dissemination strategy that identified the best and most efficient methods for reaching populations who may have interest in the PIRTEE products. Dissemination efforts included outreach through ExploreVR, NCRTM, and national networks, while sustainability planning emphasized resource integration, replication strategies, and capacity-building through initiatives such as the Trainer Community of Practice (T-CoP).

Sustainability planning included building out the iGREET section on ExploreVR, integrating Employer Engagement Core Competencies (EECC), and maintaining access to resources through a dedicated Trainer Companion Guide webpage. The T-CoP played a critical role in sustainability by equipping agency staff to deliver supplemental training internally, supported by tools, templates, and structured capstone projects.



Major Activities and Accomplishments

From the outset, PIRTEE implemented a comprehensive outreach and marketing plan to promote training opportunities and project resources. Early efforts included announcements via ExploreVR e-newsletters, social media, and marketing through CSAVR, NCSAB, and the National Clearinghouse of Rehabilitation Training Materials (NCRTM) newsletters and announcements. As the project progressed, recruitment strategies expanded to include personalized outreach to VR directors, collaboration with George Washington (GW) University's Training Director CoP, and engagement with national networks, such as CSAVR's NET single points of contact. Marketing and dissemination materials including e-announcements, flyers, registration forms, and dedicated ExploreVR pages for all training components; virtual and online courses; and leadership, supervisor, T-CoP, and Training-on-Demand sessions. PIRTEE used the following dissemination channels:

- » **ExploreVR:** Training updates and resources were disseminated monthly via the ExploreVR e-newsletter, reaching thousands of rehabilitation stakeholders.
- » **NCRTM:** Training updates and resources were disseminated via the clearinghouse newsletter and their web portal.
- » **Partner Dissemination Mechanisms:** Announcements were shared via partner and CAT e-newsletters and networks. The PIRTEE also presented at partner meetings (e.g., NET regional meetings) and CoPs (e.g., GWU's Training Director CoP).
- » **Conference Presentations:** The project team presented findings and recruited participants at major conferences, including CSAVR and NCSAB meetings.

Dissemination activities were supported by the Knowledge Translation and M&C teams, which curated and highlighted employer engagement resources through monthly ExploreVR e-newsletters. The team also worked on embedding tools and videos into the Canvas, the LMS, for online modules, incorporating employer and business relations staff perspectives through recorded interviews. Collaboration with the Innovative Training Grants Collaborative and Technical Assistance Center Collaborative (TACC) ensured alignment with other national initiatives and reduced duplication of effort. The PIRTEE project co-directors and RSA project officer made the decision in Year 2 to hold off on uploading training products to either ExploreVR or NCRTM to generate interest and participation in the training offerings.

In Years 3–4, in addition to marketing and outreach, dissemination efforts included uploading the companion guides and related resources to ExploreVR. The training resources, such as tip sheets, case scenarios, worksheets, and other material used in the training (as well as the train-the-trainer guide) were uploaded to a secure portal on ExploreVR for T-CoP participants. Individuals participating in T-CoP were required to complete the online course and therefore also had access to all the content in Canvas. The other companion guides were made available on ExploreVR and NCRTM once they were finalized. The leadership/supervisor guide was also emailed to individuals who registered for the corresponding trainings.

All products, resources, and training material were uploaded to ExploreVR and NCRTM for general dissemination upon the completion of the last virtual training cohort. Prior to submission, all the material was reviewed for 508 compliance. Some tools like the *Employer Engagement Core Competencies for VR Professionals and Individualized Business Plan* template were also added to the Business Engagement Toolkit. In addition, the training team created new products, such as success stories and informational handouts, from the discussions and content developed for the Training-on-Demand sessions.



Collaboration

PIRTEE leveraged strategic partnerships with professional VR and educator membership organizations and other RSA funded centers to maximize reach and access to evidence-based and emerging employer engagement practices. Key collaborators included the following organizations:

- » The Innovative Training Grants Collaborative: Facilitated resource sharing among similar grantees.
- » CSAVR, NCSAB, CANAR, and the NET: Critical for reaching state/Tribal VR directors and business relations leads.
- » Technical Assistance (TA) Centers (e.g., WINTAC, Vocational Rehabilitation Technical Assistance Center for Quality Management, Vocational Rehabilitation Technical Assistance Center for Quality Employment, and AIVRTTAC): Used for cross-pollination of resources.
- » Research, KT Centers, and Professional Organizations of Educators: Association of Community Rehabilitation Educators (ACRE), The National Council on Rehabilitation Education (NCRE), and the National Rehabilitation Information Center (NARIC) and Knowledge Translation for Employment Research Center (KTER): Used for identification of evidence-based practices and cross-pollination of resources.

In addition to working collaboratively with key stakeholders, the PIRTEE promoted the power of building relationships with the business community and with WIOA partners. The following Impact Story highlights how one of the training participants embraced the spirit of partnership with her fellow training cohort members.

Impact Story: The Power of Collaboration

Early in the COVID-19 pandemic, CoP members reported a high number of job seekers wanting remote work opportunities. There were many initial concerns about remote work: accommodations and support needs, supervision needs, technology skill requirements, and more. Discussions focused on the following challenges:

- » It requires a capacity to work independently.
- » It can be socially isolating.
- » For a person with limited experience, it restricts time with more experienced staff to network and benefit from informal workplace conversations.
- » It is not always an option (for example, in production or manufacturing settings or in human service jobs requiring an in-person presence).

However, remote work became a COVID reality, and for business staff, it could be challenging to identify adequate opportunities for remote work to meet the caseload needs. It also meant making minor adjustments to their employer interactions and questions.

While the CoP planned how to engage in discussions with businesses about such remote opportunities, a CoP member from New York ACCES-VR began developing a master list of companies that hired remote workers. Some information was gathered through her outreach to businesses, and some was gathered by exploring the businesses' web pages. She also discovered a master list in Forbes magazines of the top companies with remote worker needs. She shared her list of companies, many of them national businesses. She encouraged everyone to continue to add to the list to benefit the larger group.



Sustainability

PIRTEE embedded sustainability in the program design for continuation and replication after federal funding ends. In Year 5, a formal Sustainability and Dissemination Plan was finalized with an update made in October 2025 with the award of iGREET 2.0. The sustainability plan includes the following approaches: a) demonstrable effectiveness, b) coordination across federally funded projects and rehabilitation programs, c) iGREET champions, d) trainings embedded as a core staff development component for VR agencies and service providers, and e) training material remaining publicly available post award.

Demonstrable Effectiveness

The PIRTEE used evidence-based practices of successful employer engagement strategies for curriculum content to benefit future adoption of the practices. The research informed the identification of the Employer Engagement Core Competencies for VR Professionals and the curriculum development. The project designed and implemented a comprehensive evaluation plan to capture the effectiveness of the program. The PIRTEE used multiple dissemination outlets to disseminate the results of the program and build recognition for success, including impact stories and a comprehensive final report.

Coordination across Federally Funded Projects and Rehabilitation Programs

PIRTEE recruited and engaged the Curriculum Advisory Team (CAT) from target audiences that can use and promote the materials in their trainings, research, and technical assistance delivery. The project coordinated efforts across related projects, Centers and organizations to leverage resources and promote use (see collaboration section above). The PIRTEE developed a Faculty Companion Guide and outreached to academic training programs to encourage embedding the training modules into their course curriculum. As an executive member of ACRE, the PI continues to coordinate related training efforts between the two organizations.

iGREET Champions

Through the delivery of training, a number of iGREET champions have emerged and they are actively promoting the use of the training. Two state VR agencies, Wyoming Department of Workforce Services – Vocational Rehabilitation Division and Minnesota State Services for the Blind are using the iGREET for capacity building in their Disability Innovation Fund (DIF) projects. The Director of the Choctaw TVR program participated in the virtual training and subsequently attended the leadership training, join the T-CoP and requested a Training-on-Demand for her staff and other TVR programs in her region. She has been promoting the training at CANAR and other TVR meetings. Other examples are highlighted as impact stories Goals 3 and 4.

Trainings Embedded as a Core Staff Development Component for VR Agencies and Service Providers

The PIRTEE recruited VR leadership/supervisors to join CAT and developed training modules specifically targeted for leadership/supervisors to gain their buy-in, support their development of agency wide adoption, and to promote the training to other VR leaders. The project also disseminated program impacts to VR leadership/supervisors via conference presentations and through coordination with dual-customer implementation projects to educate them on the importance of the trainings in meeting WIOA employer engagement goals. Lastly, the PIRTEE developed a training guide and delivered trainings (T-CoP) to agency training directors and business relations unit managers for ongoing training for new staff. T-CoP members have continued to use the online iGREET course, the accompanying Trainer Companion Guide, and supplemental resources to train agency staff after the completion of the T-CoP.



Training Material Remaining Publicly Available Post Award

The PIRTEE products, tools, and companion guides have been uploaded to ExploreVR and linked to the Business Engagement Toolkit. Since ExploreVR is used across VR projects, the site will remain active past the end of PIRTEE. It will continue to be the portal for all future employer engagement VR related projects including iGREET 2.0. The free-standing iGREET asynchronously online course has been permanently added to the Canvas Course Catalog and will continue to be available post PIRTEE. In addition, the training material will inform future research and training and technical assistance projects. Training material will also continue to be available via the NCRTM repository of resources.



Outcomes and Impact

Dissemination and sustainability efforts have significantly amplified the reach and impact of the PIRTEE project. Outreach campaigns and partnerships resulted in high registration numbers for virtual and online trainings, with participants representing VR agencies, CRPs, and other workforce partners nationwide. ExploreVR and NCRTM have become central hubs for accessing iGREET resources, including training modules, companion guides, and employer engagement tools. The integration of the *Employer Engagement Core Competencies for VR Professionals* into the ExploreVR Business Engagement Toolkit further supports the adoption of best practices across agencies.

Collaboration with national networks and technical assistance centers strengthened the project's visibility and facilitated cross-promotion of resources. The T-CoP model ensured sustainability by creating internal capacity within agencies to continue training efforts beyond the grant period. Trainers successfully implemented capstone projects, enrolling staff in online modules and conducting follow-up sessions to reinforce learning. Feedback from T-CoP participants highlighted the value of collaborative problem-solving and resource sharing, contributing to systemic improvements in employer engagement practices.

By Year 6, PIRTEE established a robust dissemination infrastructure and sustainability framework that guarantees ongoing access to high-quality training and resources. These efforts position VR agencies to maintain and evolve employer engagement strategies, ensuring alignment with WIOA mandates and responsiveness to emerging trends in the labor market.



APPENDIX A:

CURRICULUM ADVISORY TEAM (CAT) MEMBERSHIP

1. **John Marchioro**, training director and National Employment Team lead, Illinois Division of Rehabilitation Services, and lead committee member on several Illinois Workforce system committees, including the Service Integration Policy Workgroup, Integrated Business Service Committee, and the Illinois WIOA State Summit Committee. He brought business relations, workforce system partnership, and training expertise to CAT.
2. **Tonia Peterson**, program consultant manager and National Employment Team lead, Michigan Rehabilitation Services. She brought business relations expertise to CAT.
3. **Angel Hale**, director of VR, Oregon Commission for the Blind, brought VR administrator and supervisor, business relations, and blindness services expertise to CAT.
4. **Libby Stone-Sterling**, director, Maine Division of Vocational Rehabilitation, Department of Labor brought VR administrator and supervisor, business relations, and workforce system partnerships expertise to CAT.
5. **Josh Woodward**, director of the office of business development and National Employment Team lead, Mississippi Department of Rehabilitation Services, brought business relations, supervisor, and NET single point of contact expertise to CAT.
6. **Amanda Gerson**, coordinator of vocational rehabilitation, business relations and transition services, New Jersey Commission for the Blind and Visually Impaired, oversees the transition and business relations unit and brought business relations staff supervision and blindness services expertise to CAT.
7. **Kathy West-Evans**, director of business relations, Council of State Administrators of Vocational Rehabilitation (CSAVR), brought business relations and the National Employment Team (NET) expertise to CAT.
8. **Celeste Hunt**, program director, Lumbee Tribal Vocational Rehabilitation Services brought tribal disability and training expertise to CAT.
9. **Kathy Murphy**, director, Center on Knowledge Translation for Employment Research (KTER Center), the Center on Knowledge Translation for Disability and Rehabilitation Research, and the Employment and Economic Opportunity Program at the American Institutes for Research (AIR), brought disability business development and knowledge translation strategies to CAT.
10. **Laurie Ford**, interim director and former director of VR projects at the Center for Continuing Education in Rehabilitation (CCER) in the Department of Rehabilitation Medicine at the University of Washington and VR projects director, University of Washington, brought business engagement, CRP, curriculum development, and training expertise to CAT.
11. **Chaz Compton**, director, Workforce Innovation Technical Assistance Center (WINTAC) and Vocational Rehabilitation Technical Assistance Center for Quality Management (VRTAC-QM) at San Diego State University Interwork Institute, brought VR supervisor and administrator and CRP expertise to CAT.



12. **Hugh Bradshaw**, assistant director for workforce development, Vermont Department of Labor and Employment Services, and manager at the Division of Vocational Rehabilitation, brought business relations and workforce expertise to CAT.
13. **Lucy Gafford**, director, University of Northern Texas Workplace Inclusion & Sustainable Employment (WISE), formerly worked as a transition vocational rehabilitation counselor, a unit program specialist, and an area manager for Texas DARS, runs training and a consultancy and brought curriculum development, training, academic program awareness, and leadership expertise to CAT.
14. **Amy Gonzalez**, founder & principal, AMG Consulting LLC, is a national consultant in the disability public policy field, and brought WIOA, employer engagement, and program reporting requirements expertise to CAT.
15. **Cedric Woods**, director, Institute for New England Native American Studies, University of Massachusetts Boston and a citizen of the Lumbee Tribe of North Carolina, brought academic and tribal expertise to CAT.
16. **Sheila Fesko**, former associate dean, School for Global Inclusion and Social Development (SGISD), University of Massachusetts Boston, and former graduate program director for SGISD's Rehabilitation Counseling Master's Program, and former project director for the online College of Employment Services curriculum, brought academic, curriculum development, and VR services expertise to CAT.





APPENDIX B: IGREET COURSE DESCRIPTION

Module 1: Foundations of Employer Engagement

Lesson 1- Understanding the Expectations of WIOA and The Dual-Customer Approach

- » Describes the philosophical and legislative evolution of employer engagement within the Vocational Rehabilitation (VR) agency, leading to opportunities established within WIOA
- » Includes the opportunities available for the VR agency to collaborate as an invaluable workforce and economic development partner
- » Discusses how employer engagement (and subsequent economic development) activities better position the agency to facilitate employment for people with disabilities

Lesson 2 – Ethical Considerations for Effective Employer Engagement

- » Effective employment engagement incorporates the professional code of ethics, including relationship boundaries, confidentiality, promoting equity, and more
- » Incorporates the essential elements of ethics in employer engagement activities
- » Reviews and practices using an ethical decision-making model when providing employer engagement services

Lesson 3 – Language and Communication for Effective Employer Engagement

- » Recognizes and effectively uses the power of language within employer engagement activities, but also with internal-agency communication and with external partners.
- » Understands the elements of trust, and how those are integrated into effective communication
- » Uses effective communication strategies
- » Recognizes and understands the power and necessity of business-friendly language

Lesson 4 – Preparing for, Coordinating, and Initiating Employer Engagement Activities

- » Uses preliminary research before employer contacts, understanding/finding labor market information, and employer mapping
- » Understands professionalism in employer engagement, including timing, language, listening, and impressions
- » Initiates employer engagement, like using an elevator pitch, identifying needs, and answering questions and concerns



Module 2: Developing and Maximizing Partnerships for Employer Engagement

Lesson 1 – Tapping into Internal Expertise and Connections

- » Understands the agency's employer engagement vision as well as the process for sharing internal information, contacts, and responsibilities
- » Identifies internal data collection methods and sharing
- » Explores internal networking, teams (including NET connection), communication strategies, and areas of expertise

Lesson 2 – Building an Employer Engagement Portfolio

- » Provides services to employers, including having a portfolio of services and areas of expertise (consultation) provided by the agency
- » Identifies agency-led training and consultation services to be offered, as well as areas that the agency could continue to grow
- » Identifies areas of knowledge that employer engagement staff can become knowledgeable, including employment laws and policies, resources, and more
- » Identifies agency messaging (marketing) opportunities, as well as areas of messaging expansion (website, publications, partner messaging, NET PSA)

Lesson 3 – Cultivating External Partners

- » Identifies the variety of external partnerships, including workforce system partners, employer outreach and advocacy organizations, and business organizations that may support employer services
- » Cultivates partnerships that fit the variety of opportunities available within economic development activities
- » Recognizes the steps to developing partnerships and how to move along the partnership continuum

Lesson 4 – Leveraging Partnerships

- » Identifies opportunities to leverage and adapt partnerships to meet and fulfill employer and community goals (includes AJCs, Community Colleges, CRPs, trade associations, cultural entities)
- » In leveraging those partnerships, the learner identifies, organizes, and promotes the expertise and services provided by the various partner agencies for job fairs, work-based learning, employer recognition, sector partnerships, and more
- » Identifies characteristics of effective partnerships as strategies to repair relationships, if needed



Module 3: Individualized Employer Engagement

Lesson 1- Understanding the Employer Landscape

- » Effectively uses and maximizes labor market information (LMI) to understand business sectors in terms of who is represented in the community and who is growing/expanding
- » Uses a variety of market and sector research opportunities (including TCI+)
- » Recognizes and responds to different types of businesses with appropriate and varying approaches

Lesson 2 – Every Business is Unique: Tailor Your Approach

- » Recognizes the opportunities for individualizing services to business with the use of Individualized Business Plans (IBPs)
- » Identifies and practices the steps for creating an IBP, including conducting a needs analysis, creating a proposal, and responding to changes and challenges
- » Is aware of and incorporates business cultural considerations, including size, location, values, leadership, and ownership

Lesson 3 – Environmental, Economic, and Other Challenging Situations in Employer Engagement

- » Identifies strategies for adjusting employer engagement practices in response to environmental and economic challenges
- » Recognizes opportunities in supporting employers to adjust work settings and expectations as a result of workplace and environmental conditions
- » Identifies consultative resources and services that can be provided to support employers, including knowledge of disaster preparedness, lessons learned, assistive technology, and employment laws
- » Develops employer services during economic downturns and times of little or no hiring



Module 4: Employment Models to Meet Business Needs

Lesson 1- Meeting Employer Needs while Achieving Competitive Integrated Employment (CIE)

- » Develops creative employment solutions to meet business needs, including developing a flexible mindset, nuanced assessment methods, and having developed trusting employer relationships
- » Understands that the core of CIE incorporates customer informed choice and awareness of employment opportunities and strategies
- » Employers aren't aware of CIE, but agency staff uses CIE as a guidepost when developing economic opportunities
- » The employment practices included in this module are opportunities to meet hiring needs of employers in creative and unique ways

Lesson 2 – Meeting Employer Needs through Work-Based Learning & Progressive Employment

- » Understands work-based learning, including key principles, types of learning opportunities, benefits to employers, and examples
- » Understands Progressive Employment, including essential elements, advantages to employers, and examples

Lesson 3 – Meeting Employer Needs Through Apprenticeships & Career Pathways

Understands the following concepts, including the essential elements, advantages to employers, and examples

- » Pre-apprenticeship
- » Apprenticeship
- » On-the-Job Training
- » Career Pathways, additionally including integration of educational instruction, workforce development, and vocational supports